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No Half Truths

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736 DDA PARKS, 16 ON CAMERA: AUDIT P3



PARGAT SINGH APPOINTED PUNJAB CONG CHIEF P5

NUSHRRATT BHARUCCHA SUFFERS SPINAL FRACTURE IN BALI P12

EC orders special drive for voters left out during SIR

Says eligible citizens should not lose voting rights

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, October 2



PIC/ANI

KEY POINTS

- EC orders special drive for voters left out after SIR
- Drive covers 20 states and Union Territories
- Young and first-time voters also eligible
- Form 6 to be used for enrolment
- BLOs to verify pre-SIR and post-SIR rolls
- House-to-house checks ordered for missing voters
- BLOs to cover 20-25 electors weekly
- Verification drive to finish within one month
- Political parties' booth agents to assist verification

The Election Commission has directed electoral authorities in 20 states and Union Territories where the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls has been completed to launch special drives to identify and enrol eligible voters who were left out, along with young and first-time electors. The move comes amid scrutiny over large-scale deletions during the revision, with around 13 crore names removed from draft rolls across 30 states and Union Territories, though the figure includes voters who may have been deceased, duplicated, shifted or otherwise ineligible. The Commission has said no eligible citizen should lose the right to vote merely because their name was not included during the SIR process.

The directive was issued in writing on September 29 and reiterated at a video conference with state Chief Electoral Officers on Thursday. Under the exercise, District Election Officers and Electoral Registration Officers will facilitate enrolment through the continuous updation process, using Form 6, the statutory application for inclusion in the electoral roll. The Commission has also made clear that the additional declaration introduced into Form 6 during the SIR will apply only during the SIR phase. Outside that phase, applicants will use the forms prescribed under the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960.

Booth-level officers have been asked to compare the electoral rolls prepared CONTINUED ON P4

FROM DELHI TO MUMBAI, DEMANDS GROW FOR CEC'S RESIGNATION

'Gyanesh Kumar go back': Opposition, student groups hit streets over SIR; over 700 detained

AIMAN FATIMA
New Delhi, October 2



PIC/PTI

HIGHLIGHT

- Gandhi Jayanti protests target electoral-roll revision
- AAP, AISA, SFI join separate demonstrations
- DYFI and NSUI workers also protest
- Among those detained were former Delhi chief minister Atishi, AAP leader Saurabh Bharadwaj, AAP MP Sanjay Singh, RJD leader Manoj Jha, AISA president Neha Bora and political activist Yogendra Yadav

Demands for greater accountability and transparency in the electoral process echoed across Delhi on Friday, leading to the detention of more than 700 protesters by Delhi Police as opposition parties, student groups and youth organisations held separate demonstrations around Jantar Mantar not far from Parliament House, demanding resignation of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar over alleged irregularities in the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls and the deletion of voters.

The demonstrations coincided with Gandhi Jayanti and saw participation from the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP), All India Students' Association (AISA), Students' Federation of India (SFI), Democratic Youth Federation CONTINUED ON P4

'Jantar Mantar 2.0' warning at Mumbai protest



PIC/PTI

MPOST BUREAU
Mumbai, October 2

Thousands of young protesters gathered at Mumbai's Shivaji Park on Friday for a Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) demonstration demanding the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar, turning the Gandhi Jayanti gathering into a high-profile political protest attended by actors Naseeruddin Shah and Shabana Azmi, filmmakers Vishal Bhardwaj and Hansal Mehta, singer-music director Vishal Dadlani and Mahatma Gandhi's great-grandson Tushar Gandhi. The protest, held amid heavy police deployment and opposition from some local residents, was organised over allegations concerning the Election Commission's handling of electoral rolls and the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) process.

CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke told the gathering that the agitation would CONTINUED ON P4

Briefs

Pargat Singh new Punjab Congress chief

NEW DELHI: The Congress on Friday appointed former Indian hockey captain Pargat Singh the president of the Punjab Pradesh Congress Committee after Amarinder Singh Raja Warring submitted his resignation earlier in the day. SEE P5

Gujarat now 2nd state to adopt UCC

AHMEDABAD: The Gujarat Uniform Civil Code (UCC) Bill 2026 has received the assent of President Droupadi Murmu, paving the way for implementation of the legislation, a notification published in the Gujarat Government Gazette has informed. Gujarat has become the second Indian state after Uttarakhand to get approval to implement the UCC. SEE P6

In phone call, Modi praises flydubai pilot, hears account of mid-air ordeal

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, Oct 2



PIC/PTI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Friday spoke to Captain Smit Machchhar, the Indian pilot who was seriously injured after his co-pilot allegedly attacked him inside the cockpit of a Dubai-Tel Aviv flight, and praised his decision to keep fighting despite his injuries to prevent the aircraft from going down. Machchhar, speaking from a hospital in the UAE, told Modi that he was fighting for his own life but knew he could not let the 174 people aboard the flight die. He said his 17 years of flying experience, including 11 as a captain, helped him understand the danger even while he was lying injured on the cockpit floor.

Flydubai flight FZ1073 was flying from Dubai to Tel Aviv on Wednesday when Machchhar was attacked. The aircraft, carrying 174 passengers, including 27 children, transmitted emergency signals and rapidly descended more than 17,000 feet from 34,000 feet before being diverted to Prince Sultan Bin Abdulaziz Airport in Tabuk, Saudi Arabia. CONTINUED ON P4

Centre formally marks 28 strategic Ladakh sites on India's official map

MPOST BUREAU
New Delhi, October 2

The Centre has formally identified 28 strategic places and geographical features in Ladakh on the official Survey of India map, including Gogra and Hot Spring, two key friction points along the Line of Actual Control (LAC).

The government said the names were finalised in consultation with the Ladakh administration to ensure standardised identification on official maps and improve public awareness of the sensitive border region.

"Government of India, in consultation with the Union Territory of Ladakh, has identified a total of twenty-eight (28) places/features, located in the UT of Ladakh, by standard place and feature names on the official map of Survey of India," it said.

Gogra and Hot Spring were among the areas that witnessed friction between CONTINUED ON P4

Gold and LA 2028 ticket

India's women return to Asian Games hockey summit after 44 years



Women's hockey team celebrates after winning gold medal PTI

MPOST BUREAU
Kakamigahara, October 2

India ended a 44-year wait for Asian Games women's hockey gold on Friday, beating defending champions China 1-0 in a tense final to secure both the title and direct qualification for the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics, in a day that produced a six-gold haul and pushed the country into fifth place in the overall medal standings. Lalremsiami's superb reverse-stick strike in the 10th minute gave India the decisive goal, but it was the relentless CONTINUED ON P4

KALINGA INSTITUTE OF INDUSTRIAL TECHNOLOGY
KIIT Deemed to be University
(Established U/S 3 of UGC Act 1956), Bhubaneswar, Odisha, India
Organisation in Special Consultative Status with the United Nations Economic & Social Council (UN-ECOSOC)

Slow and Steady Wins the Race...

THE World University Rankings 2027

4th Best
Among All Universities in India

1st in Eastern India

501+ Cohort Globally



Every year, Times Higher Education (THE) publishes its World University Rankings. This year, THE has released the World University Rankings 2027. KIIT has emerged as one of the **best** and **most promising universities** in **India** and **across the globe**. KIIT ranks **4th** among both goverment and private universities in India and is placed in the **501–550 global cohort**. It has also maintained its **1st position** in **Eastern India** despite increased institutional participation worldwide.

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- Student Friendly Campus — Student-centric approach with comprehensive support services
- Best Placement — Excellent Opportunities & Career Outcomes
- Parent-Friendly Institution — Transparent communication & parent engagement
- Modern Student Library — 24×7 Study Space for Focused Learning

KIIT is an institute of 29 years (1997–2026) and a Deemed to be University of only 22 years (2004–2026)

KIIT-DU, Patia, Bhubaneswar, Odisha, India 751024 | kiit@kiit.ac.in | www.kiit.ac.in

KIIT (Deemed to be University) has only one permanent campus in Bhubaneswar, Odisha.
It has no other campus / off campus anywhere else in the country and globe.

AQI on Friday: 173

Saturday, October 3, 2026
NEW DELHI
Temp on Friday
MAX 36°C MIN 23.2°C

FORECAST

Millenniumpost

45 buses seized & 70+ fined in safety drive after fatal fire

Nine passengers were killed after bus caught fire on Yamuna e-way

DIPIKA KIROLA
Noida. October 2

Traffic police and transport department teams seized 45 buses and issued challans to more than 70 others during a four-day crackdown on passenger vehicles for safety and regulatory violations. The challans amounted to over Rs 5 lakh.

The action comes days after nine passengers were charred to death when a bus caught fire on the Yamuna Expressway, raising questions over safety arrangements in passenger vehicles and the availability and functioning of emergency exits and fire-fighting equipment.

Traffic police checked over 1,000 buses between September 27 and 30 as part of the intensified enforcement drive. Officials examined emergency exits, CCTV cameras, fire extinguishers and other fire-safety equipment, besides checking curtains, black film and other violations. Drunk-driving checks were also conducted during the drive. Drivers and conductors were briefed about passenger safety, the use of emergency equipment and precautions to be taken in case of a fire or other emergency.

Separately, the transport department launched Operation Kavach 2.0 on September 27 to crack down on unauthorised and rule-violating buses operating on various routes. Five teams were deployed for surprise inspections. The teams seized 11 buses on the first day, 19 buses on second day, another 15 buses on third, taking the total number of seized buses to 45 under the operation. Along with seizures by traffic police, challans were also issued.



VIGILANCE DRIVE

- Traffic police checked over 1,000 buses between September 27 and 30 as part of the intensified enforcement drive. Officials examined emergency exits, CCTV cameras, fire extinguishers and other fire-safety equipment
- Drunk-driving checks were also conducted during the drive. Drivers and conductors were briefed about passenger safety, the use of emergency equipment and precautions to be taken in case of a fire or other emergency

Unlike routine challans, the seized buses will also undergo technical examination before they are allowed to resume operations. Officials said the vehicles would be released only after they are found compliant with the prescribed AIS-119 safety norms. If a bus is found to have serious safety deficiencies or other violations, action could include suspension of its registration and fitness certificate.

The intensified scrutiny has also brought the issue of unauthorised modifications in sleeper buses into focus. During recent checks, officials found that some buses undergo structural and passenger-compartment modifications after obtaining fitness certificates and regulatory clearances.

Bus workers said some sleeper buses originally designed with a 2x1 layout, accommodating around 36 berths, are subsequently modified into 2x2 layouts to carry as many as 48 passengers. Such modifications can reduce aisle space and berth dimensions, potentially making movement inside the bus difficult, particularly during an emergency evacuation.

Officials said alterations to the passenger compartment, electrical systems, air-conditioning units or other major components can affect the vehicle's original safety configuration and therefore cannot be treated as cosmetic changes.

"Any alteration that changes the passenger compartment, electrical load or other safety-related components has to be properly engineered, inspected and certified," said a senior official involved in the enforcement drive.

The crackdown follows the deadly bus fire on the Yamuna Expressway in which nine passengers were trapped inside the vehicle and were charred to death. The incident has prompted authorities to step up inspections of passenger buses, particularly those operating on highways and intercity routes.

A senior traffic police officer said the enforcement would not be limited to the current three-day drive. "The drive will continue against buses operating illegally or in violation of safety norms. Vehicles found compromising passenger safety will be taken off the road and strict action will be initiated against their operators," the officer said.

Officials said the focus would remain on identifying buses that do not meet mandatory safety requirements and ensuring that vehicles with serious deficiencies do not return to the roads without completing the prescribed technical and regulatory checks.

50-yr-old man dies, son injured as house collapses in Jwalapuri

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi. October 2

A 50-year-old man died, and his 20-year-old son was injured after their ground-plus-one-storey house collapsed in outer Delhi's Jwalapuri area, an official said on Friday.

The Delhi Fire Service (DFS) said the incident took place around 4 pm on Thursday near Udyog Nagar Metro station.

The house, spread over around 25 square yards, collapsed, trapping the father and son under the debris.



A DFS team rescued the two and rushed them to Sanjay Gandhi Hospital, where the father, Samsuhal, was declared dead, while his son, Soheb, was admitted with a back injury, they said.

THE HOUSE, SPREAD OVER AROUND 25 SQUARE YARDS, COLLAPSED, TRAPPING THE FATHER AND SON UNDER THE DEBRIS

251 held in month-long crackdown

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi. October 2

Delhi Police has arrested 251 people and registered 180 cases under various laws during a month-long crime crackdown in north Delhi aimed at curbing street crime, illegal gambling, drug peddling, bootlegging and possession of illegal arms, officials said on Friday.

The drive was conducted from September 1 to 30, during which teams from police stations and specialised units intensified patrolling, checking and surveillance at vulnerable locations across the district, they said.

As part of the action against robbers and snatchers, police registered 28 cases and arrested 40 people. They recovered 20 mobile phones, three gold rings, two gold chains, two pistols and four knives, besides two-wheelers, officials said.

In cases registered under the NDPS Act, 23 people were arrested and 12.6 kg of ganja, 211.3 grams of charas, 132.24 grams of smack, 100 buprenorphine tablets, 10 vials of avil injection and 10 hypodermic syringes with needles were recovered, police said.



"DRIVE WAS CONDUCTED FROM SEPT 1-30, DURING WHICH TEAMS FROM POLICE STNS AND SPECIALISED UNITS INTENSIFIED PATROLLING, CHECKING AND SURVEILLANCE AT VULNERABLE LOCATIONS

Police also registered 22 cases under the Excise Act and arrested 24 people, recovering 1,779 quarter bottles, 35 bottles of liquor and 117 beer cans. The liquor was allegedly being brought from adjoining states for illegal distribution in Delhi, they said.

The drive against illegal gambling led to the registration of 13 cases and the arrest of 69 people. Stake money amounting to Rs 2.32 lakh, two mobile phones and playing cards were seized, police said.

A total of 88 cases relating to theft, burglary, motor vehicle theft and other offences were registered, leading to the arrest of 88 people. Seven proclaimed offenders were also arrested, officials said.

Police said 30 two-wheelers and two auto-rickshaws were recovered during the drive. The overall recovery also included 75 mobile phones, 53 illegal e-cigarettes/vapes, two sacks of cardamom, 25 cartons of bidis and cash amounting to around Rs 6.62 lakh.

Court acquits two men in 2018 firing, robbery case

New Delhi. October 2

A Delhi court has acquitted two men accused of robbing and shooting a man at a metro station in 2018, observing that the prosecution failed to establish their identity as the assailants or scientifically link the recovered pistol to the firing.

Additional Sessions Judge Twinkle Wadhwa acquitted Deepak alias Golu and Shanu alias Furkan in the case registered at Karawal Nagar police station under provisions of the IPC and Arms Act.

According to the prosecution, Aas Mohd had gone to Jawahar Nagar Metro Station on April 27, 2018, when three boys allegedly tried to snatch his mobile phone. On resisting, one of them allegedly fired at him with a country-made pistol, injuring his right arm.

Police apprehended Deepak and Shanu the following day and claimed that Aas Mohd identified them. A country-made pistol was subsequently recovered at Shanu's instance.

However, Aas Mohd denied before the court that the two men were the assailants or that he had identified them earlier. The court noted that he was the only eyewitness and there was no CCTV footage or other eyewitness evidence to support the prosecution. The court also found the weapon recovery doubtful, noting that Aas Mohd denied witnessing it despite his signature appearing on the seizure memo. The court found the recovery unsupported and forensic evidence inconclusive, leaving the prosecution unable to establish the weapon's connection to the shooting. MPOST

Delhi University relaxes passing criteria for 2025-2026 batch, teachers flag concerns over academic standards

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi. October 2

The University of Delhi has relaxed the passing criteria for students of the 2025-26 batch as a one-time measure, prompting concerns among teachers over the timing of the decision and its implications for transparency and consistency in the examination system.

According to a notification issued by the university's Controller of Examinations on Thursday, students of the 2025-26 academic batch who have completed one year of study will be exempted from the requirement of securing 28 credits out of 44 credits for promotion. The exemption will apply only to the 2025-26 batch and not to subsequent batches.



'PASSING CRITERIA FOR A SPECIFIC BATCH ARE BEING RELAXED WITHOUT EXPLAINING WHICH CIRCUMSTANCES, HARDSHIPS OR SYSTEMIC FAILURE WARRANT SUCH A CHANGE'

The notification said all other provisions of the earlier notifications issued would remain unchanged and that the decision had been taken with the approval of the competent authority. Delhi University teachers, however, have questioned the rationale and timing of the move, particularly since the students concerned have already moved into their third semester.

Abha Dev Habib, secretary of the Delhi University Teachers' Federation (DTF) and an associate professor at Miranda House, questioned why the passing criteria had been changed without specifying the circumstances or hardships that necessitated the exemption.

"Passing criteria for a specific batch (2025-26) are being relaxed without explaining which circumstances, hardships or systemic failure warrant such a change," Habib said.

She also questioned whether the move could have been necessitated by a large number of students failing to meet the prescribed criteria, and raised concerns over the possibility of selective benefit, while referring to what she described as earlier instances of changes in academic qualification requirements. Habib further pointed out that classes for the third semester began on July 28, while examination results continued to be declared through August, and questioned whether the passing criteria could be altered after students had already entered the next semester.

"Transparency and stability of the examination system is an important aspect for a good university. DU is being systemically damaged," she said. Rudrashish Chakraborty, DTF treasurer, associate professor in the Department of English at Kirori Mal College and a former member of the university's Academic Council, also questioned the decision.

He alleged that the notification reflected "incompetence" in handling the growing number of papers under the National Education Policy (NEP) and raised concerns over the manner in which the policy was being implemented.

Chakraborty also alleged that the move could potentially benefit an individual with political connections, while questioning whether the relaxation reflected inadequate preparation for the implementation of the NEP.

Gurugram launches 'Garbage Vulnerable Points free' drive

OUR CORRESPONDENT
Gurugram. October 2

The Garbage Vulnerable Points (GVPs) free campaign was launched here on Mahatma Gandhi Jayanti on Friday as part of the 'Swachhata Hi Seva 2026' initiative and the ongoing Seva Sankalp Abhiyaan in Haryana.

Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini inspected a GVP-free site developed by the Municipal Corporation of Gurugram near the DHBVN Colony on Mehrauli Road and formally launched the campaign.

According to an official statement, Saini said cleanliness should not be limited to government arrangements and stressed the importance of active citizen participation.



The government can provide systems, facilities, modern technology and resources, but segregating waste generated by households and institutions is the responsibility of citizens, he said.

Saini identified government systems, modern technology and public participation as three key aspects of the cleanliness campaign and said the objective was to turn the drive into a broad-based citizens' campaign.

He appealed to people not to throw waste in the open, to segregate waste at source, and to hand over garbage only to authorised waste collection vehicles.

Under the campaign, special cleanliness drives will be conducted at 21 identified GVPs across Gurugram, aiming to turn them into clean, improved public spaces. The campaign carries the message, "10 Days - 21 Garbage Points - One Gurugram".

The October 2-11 campaign will target identified dumping spots, with civic officials urging residents, shopkeepers, schools and RWAs to join cleanliness and waste segregation efforts.

Traffic police challan 154 buses in spl drive

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi. October 2

The Delhi Traffic Police challaned 154 buses and impounded two others during a special enforcement drive across the city to curb traffic violations and promote road safety, officials said on Friday.

The drive was conducted on October 1 across various traffic circles and major roads in Delhi with focused action against violations by buses, they said.

TWO BUSES IMPOUNDED IN DELHI, SAID COPS

Special attention was given to dangerous and unauthorised driving practices that could endanger other road users and contribute to accidents and traffic congestion, officials said.

A total of 154 buses were challaned for traffic violations, while two were impounded wherever warranted under the provisions of law, they said.

TRADERS RESORT TO ALTERNATE INTERNET CONNECTIONS & CASH-ONLY SALES

Internet shutdown hits Connaught Place business

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE
New Delhi. October 2

Business activity in Connaught Place was hit on Friday as an internet shutdown imposed around Jantar Mantar amid an ongoing protest demanding the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar disrupted digital payment services, leaving customers and shopkeepers struggling to complete UPI transactions.

The Connaught Place market remained open, contrary to reports suggesting that it had been shut. However, the internet disruption, coupled with traffic restrictions and heightened security in the area, affected business at several establishments, with shopkeepers reporting a drop in sales of more than 50 per cent as customers struggled to make digital payments.

"Our sales have reduced to less than half today because of the internet shutdown. Customers are finding it difficult to make digital payments, which has severely affected business," a snack vendor in Connaught Place said.

'WE WOULD HAVE KEPT OUR SHOP CLOSED TODAY. THERE IS HARDLY ANY BUSINESS, AND ON TOP OF THAT, WE HAVE TO DEAL WITH THIS HEAT'

The vendor said the disruption had compounded the difficulties faced by small businesses. "We would have kept our shop closed today. There is hardly any business, and on top of that, we have to deal with this heat," he said.

Shopkeepers were also trying to find ways to continue accepting digital payments. An owner of a mobile accessories shop said they were using mobile hotspots provided by others in an attempt to process UPI transactions.

"We are trying to do business by using someone else's hotspot and hoping their internet connection will work for the payments," he said.

Several vendors, however, had no option but to switch to cash. A snack shop owner said the outlet was accepting only cash on Friday as the internet disruption had made digital transactions difficult.

"We are only accepting cash payments for today," the shop owner said.

Internet disruption hit UPI-dependent traders, affecting sales at outlets as the protest continued around Jantar Mantar, raising concerns over revenue.

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190 HIGH-RISK PARKS FLAGGED; 520 NEED MORE LIGHTS

736 DDA parks, 16 on camera: Audit

SHIVANGI SHUKLA
New Delhi, October 2

The Delhi Development Authority has completed a safety audit of all its 736 parks within a week, identifying 190 as high risk and requiring immediate intervention. The audit, carried out following directions of Lieutenant Governor Sardar Taranjit Singh Sandhu, has also flagged the need for additional lighting in 520 parks and new CCTV installations in 323 parks. Of the 736 parks audited, 258 have been categorised as medium risk and 288 as low risk, while the high risk parks are being addressed on an immediate basis.

Lighting is among the key gaps identified in the audit. Of the 520 parks where additional lighting provisions have been identified, 231 are being taken up for immediate provision. Work has already been completed in 106 parks on an immediate basis, based on the audit conducted last week. Access and visibility related concerns have also been identified. In 163 parks, unlockable gates have been marked for conversion into lockable gates. Safety information boards have been installed in 115 parks, with another 484 signages under implementation.

The audit found CCTV surveillance available in 16 parks, while 323 additional parks have been identified for new CCTV installations. Boundary related issues have also been taken up, with repair and missing grill work addressed in 233 of the 399 parks identified for such work. Areas around toilets and abandoned structures have been identified for corrective action. Security arrangements are also being expanded across the parks. Night patrolling has started in 245 major parks, while 134 parks have been identified for the requirement of gunmen. Bike patrolling has started in all high risk parks. A meeting with all concerned security agencies was conducted in the office of the Principal Commissioner on September 28 to address the issues.

The DDA has made biometric attendance of security guards active in 602 parks, with implementation underway in the remaining parks. Contact details of local police and beat officers have also been shared with field staff and vice versa, along with sensitisation on incident reporting and police coordination. The coverage of contact detail distribution is 100 per cent across all parks. The authority is also working on standardised security protocols, with SOPs under progress for patrolling, guard performance, supervisor accountability, attendance, reporting and police coordination. Security related tender provisions are also being updated.

At the local level, the DDA has initiated structured meetings with Resident Welfare Associations to identify park specific safety concerns and assign corrective actions. These meetings are being conducted at the Director/DD level. For continued oversight, a Central Master Tracker and Monitoring Dashboard have been established, while senior officers are conducting weekly inspections. The Principal Commissioner visited Yamuna Biodiversity Park on September 30, followed by a visit by the Principal Commissioner Kamla Nehru Ridge Park on October 1.

SAFETY CHECK

- The audit, carried out following directions of L-G Sardar Taranjit Singh Sandhu, has also flagged the need for additional lighting in 520 parks and new CCTV installations in 323 parks
- Of the 736 parks audited, 258 have been categorised as medium risk and 288 as low risk, while the high risk parks are being addressed on an immediate basis
- Lighting is among the key gaps identified in the audit. Of the 520 parks where additional lighting provisions have been identified, 231 are being taken up for immediate provision
- Work has already been completed in 106 parks on an immediate basis, based on the audit conducted last week





CM joins Azadpur cleanliness drive

AIMAN FATIMA
New Delhi, October 2

CM Rekha Gupta on Friday participated in a cleanliness drive at Azadpur on Gandhi Jayanti under the 'Seva Mera Yogdan' campaign and inspected civic conditions in the area, directing officials to take prompt action on issues related to garbage, encroachment, drainage and damaged infrastructure.

During the inspection, Gupta reviewed the condition of the central verge, footpaths, roadside walls, drainage system and nearby public spaces. She sought details from officials about garbage accumulation and footpaths being used by fruit vendors, as well as unauthorised advertisements on walls.

The chief minister directed officials to ensure regular cleaning of the central verge and surrounding areas and asked them to explore permanent solutions to civic issues. She also called for the improvement and beautification of the underpass and long walls through wall paintings.

Gupta interacted with fruit vendors operating on footpaths and said arrangements should take into account their livelihood while ensuring that footpaths remain accessible to pedestrians. She asked officials and local representatives to coordinate on a suitable arrangement for vendors and commuters.

The chief minister also urged fruit vendors and workers at Azadpur Mandi to ensure that waste generated during business is properly disposed of. She noted that waste left on footpaths could enter drains and affect the drainage system.

She further directed officials to maintain cleanliness and improve public facilities around the chowk being developed in the area. According to the government, a statue of former prime minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee is planned to be installed there in December, after which it will be named 'Atal Chowk'.

Gupta said cleanliness should not remain limited to campaigns and should become part of daily life. She stressed that maintaining clean streets, markets, neighbourhoods and other public spaces was a shared responsibility. MLA Rajkumar Bhatia, Municipal Corporation officials, other public representatives and local residents were present during the inspection.

Briefs

CAQM reviews outcomes of 197 inspections

NEW DELHI: The CAQM Enforcement Task Force (ETF) reviewed reports from 197 inspections and enforcement actions carried out in the National Capital Region area between September 8 and September 24 at its 140th meeting, a statement said on Friday. The flying squads carried out 10 inspections across construction and demolition sites, 111 inspections in the industrial sector, and 76 inspections related to diesel generator sets, among others. "As per the violations reported by the concerned sectors, various enforcement actions have been proposed. These include closure of four construction and demolition projects and an industrial unit; sealing of 28 diesel generator sets; issuance of orders or directions for compliance in 17 cases'| and environmental compensation in 10 cases," the statement said. The meeting, held on Thursday, also reviewed the actions taken during the special inspection drive conducted in Hapur, UP on September 15 by seven teams of the CAQM's flying squads, along with district administration and police personnel, and officers of the UPPCB.

Delhi records max temp of 36 degrees C

NEW DELHI: Delhi recorded a maximum temperature of 36 degrees Celsius on Friday, 1.3 degrees above normal, while the air quality remained at 173 in the 'moderate' category, according to the India Meteorological Department (IMD). The city's prime weather station at Safdarjung recorded a maximum temperature of 36 degrees Celsius, 1.3 degrees above normal. Among the other stations, Lodi Road recorded a maximum temperature of 36 degrees Celsius, three degrees above normal, and Ayanagar logged 36 degrees Celsius, 1.4 degrees above normal.

Councillors flag waste mgmt gaps

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, October 2

MCD councillors on Friday flagged gaps in waste segregation and collection in their wards and sought tighter monitoring of bulk waste generators as the civic body discussed implementation of the Solid Waste Management Rules, 2026.

At a special meeting chaired by Deputy Mayor Monika Pant, councillors sought stronger registration and compliance mechanisms for bulk waste generators, regular awareness drives and improvements in waste collection, according to a statement issued by the deputy mayor's office.

According to an official statement, the meeting also focused on four-way segregation of waste at source, with the civic body's chief engineer briefing councillors on provisions of the new rules and the need to keep different categories of waste generated by households, institutions, markets and other establishments separate.

Pant said merely creating awareness about the rules would not be enough unless they were implemented on the ground.

"Effective solid waste management requires coordination between awareness of the rules, their implementation at the ground level, and active participation of citizens," she said, according to the statement. Councillors also raised issues specific to their respective wards and suggested measures to improve segregation, collection and monitoring of bulk waste generators, besides seeking better safety and welfare measures for sanitation workers.

PROTEST



A student activist clings to a Delhi Police bus to stop it from moving away with detained protesters, while security personnel intervene during a demonstration demanding the resignation of CEC, near Jantar Mantar PTI

NDMC urges staff to follow spirit of 'Nagrik Devo Bhava'

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, October 2

The New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) has drafted a set of "10 commandments" for its employees, urging them to prioritise citizens and avoid intentional delays in public service delivery and corruption.

The commandments, which will be displayed prominently across NDMC offices, include pledges such as "I serve the citizen", "I will be honest even when nobody is watching", "I will not deliberately delay work" and "I will take ownership rather than saying 'this is not my work'".

In a September 30 circular, NDMC chairperson Manoj Kumar Dwivedi asked employees to follow the spirit of "Nagrik Devo Bhava" (citizen is God) and adhere to an 18-point code of conduct aimed at improving transparency, accountability and public service delivery. The code directs employees not to accept bribes or commissions, deliberately delay files or payments, or allow personal interests to influence official decisions. "Decisions related to tenders, contracts, recruitment and regulatory enforcement have to be based on prescribed rules and not personal connections, external pressure or political affiliations," officials said.

The civic body has also stressed the need for a citizen-friendly approach, directing employees to handle grievances politely and not force people to rely on personal contacts for basic services. Officials receiving queries outside their jurisdiction have been asked to guide citizens to the appropriate department rather than turning them away. The circular also lays down workplace conduct rules, prohibiting bullying, sexual harassment, abusive language and discrimination.

Employees have been asked to treat public money and municipal assets responsibly, with directions against inflated estimates, unnecessary expenditure and misuse of official vehicles or infrastructure.

Department heads have been cautioned against issuing illegal oral directions to subordinates. The circular encourages employees to report fraud and safety risks through official vigilance channels. Employees have also been directed to protect confidential information and ensure their personal social media activity does not interfere with official duties. Dwivedi said maintaining clean, quality public spaces is the collective responsibility of all NDMC employees, not limited to sanitation or engineering departments.

Delhi govt to build new DTC building at ₹128 cr: Officials

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, October 2

The Delhi government is constructing an 11-storeyed building of the DTC headquarters that is estimated to cost around Rs 128.23 crore, officials said on Friday.

The new building comprising two basements, ground floor and 11 storeys, will be constructed on the land of the existing headquarters building of the Delhi Transport Corporation at IP Estate Bus Depot.

Last December, DTC signed an agreement with the Delhi State Industrial Infrastructure Corporation (DSIIDC) for construction of the building. The DSSIDC has issued a tender inviting construction agencies for the project, officials said.

The estimated cost of the building will be Rs 128.23 crore and it will be built over the next two years following work award, according to the tender document.

The new building will be spread over 26,000 square metres (2.6 hectares) and will replace the old headquarters. According to the officials, the existing one has grown structurally outdated and inadequate to support the operational needs of Delhi's rapidly-expanding transport network. Out of 26,000 square metres, the operational area will be 12,234 square metres, while the new building will be located on 6,158 square metres.

The plan also incorporates a green area of 9,681.71 square metres, 20 per cent of the total land, ensuring an "environmentally-conscious and future-ready campus," officials said.

According to the MoU, 50 per cent of the commercial usage rights will remain with the DSIIDC for 30 years. The new complex will park 200 buses and will have space in the basement for more than 200 cars. Firefighting, audio-visual system, access control, CCTV network, lifts, high side and low side HVAC (heating, ventilation and air conditioning) system will be part of the new building.

HIGHLIGHTS

- The new building comprising two basements, ground floor and 11 storeys, will be constructed on the land of the existing headquarters building of the Delhi Transport Corporation at IP Estate Bus Depot
- Last December, DTC signed an agreement with the Delhi State Industrial Infrastructure Corporation (DSIIDC) for construction of the building

PROTECTING NORTHERN RIDGE VITAL FOR DELHI'S ENVIRONMENT, FUTURE GENERATIONS: CM

277.56 acres of Northern Ridge to be declared reserved forest

AIMAN FATIMA
New Delhi, October 2

The Delhi government has approved the Phase-I notification to declare 112.328 hectares, or 277.56 acres, of land in the Northern Ridge as reserved forest under Section 20 of the Indian Forest Act, 1927.

The area forms part of the Aravalli range and is considered an important green and ecological zone of the national capital. The government said the move will provide legal protection to the Northern Ridge and strengthen its long-term conservation.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said, "The Northern Ridge is an invaluable part of Delhi's natural heritage and its protection is crucial for the city's environmental health as well as for future generations."

She said the notification reflected the government's commitment to protecting Delhi's green areas. "The Northern Ridge serves as Delhi's 'green lungs' and an ecological hub. Granting it legal protection as a reserved forest will further strengthen the foundation for its long-term conservation," Gupta said.



According to the government, 5,267.009 hectares (13,014.77 acres) have been notified as reserved forest during the tenure of the present government so far, compared with 96.16 hectares (237.611 acres) under previous governments. With the Northern Ridge notification, the total area is expected to rise to 5,363.169 hectares, or around 13,252.390 acres.

The government had also approved last month the notification of around 400 hectares (1,000 acres) in the Southern Ridge as reserved forest.

Gupta said environmental conservation was closely linked to efforts to tackle pollution. "Protecting natural areas such as the Northern Ridge, expanding green areas and maintaining ecological balance will give Delhi greater long-term resilience in dealing with air pollution and climate-related challenges," she said.

The government said more than 73 lakh saplings have been planted in Delhi this year, while work on check dams and natural regeneration in Ridge areas is also underway to improve groundwater recharge. The next phase of the Northern Ridge conservation process will focus on demarcation, habitat management and community participation, the government said.

'PARTICIPANTS SHARED THEIR EXPERIENCES AND SUGGESTIONS'

Over 2.42L special gram sabhas held across country on Gandhi Jayanti

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, October 2

More than 2.42 lakh special gram sabhas were held across the country to discuss transformative governance reforms on Gandhi Jayanti, marking the Centre's launch of the People's Plan Campaign 2026-27 under which Gram Panchayats will prepare their development plans for the next financial year.

The gram sabhas held on Friday -- with participation from locals, elected representatives, Panchayat functionaries and officials -- placed various government schemes and local issues at the centre of discussions, the Ministry of Panchayati Raj said in a statement.

The special gram sabhas provided rural citizens a "direct platform" to participate in discussions on key government initiatives and issues of local relevance, it said.

The deliberations covered the devolution of Central Finance Commission grants to panchayats, financial self-reliance through own-source revenue, property and land rights, employment and livelihoods, drinking water and sanitation, water security, food security, consumer protection and women's economic empowerment.

Agenda and information on key government initiatives, including governance reforms and citizen-centric measures undertaken over the last 12 years, were read out and discussed. Participants shared their experiences and suggestions, the ministry said.



PM Narendra Modi pays floral tributes during a prayer meeting to mark Gandhi Jayanti, at Gandhi Smriti PTI

The exercise was supported by various ministries and departments as well as their field-level functionaries and MY Bharat volunteers. Their engagement at the state-, district-, block- and gram panchayat-level helped facilitate meaningful dialogue on citizen-centric schemes and initiatives while strengthening "Jan Bhagidari and Samvaad at the grassroots", it said.

Panchayati Raj Secretary Vineet Joshi and senior officials of the ministry and participating departments were in touch with officials of states and Union Territories throughout the day to review the progress of the gram sabhas and facilitate coordination, the statement said.

The special gram sabhas also marked the commencement of the People's Plan Campaign 2026-27, "Sabki Yojana, Sabka Vikas", under which panchayats will prepare their development plans for the financial year 2027-28.

The campaign, led by the Ministry of Panchayati Raj in collaboration with 21 ministries and departments, has been rolled out across all states and Union Territories since 2018 to enable panchayats to prepare evidence-based, holistic and participatory plans.

KEY POINTS

- 'The special gram sabhas provided rural citizens a "direct platform" to participate in discussions on key government initiatives and issues of local relevance'
- The exercise was supported by various ministries and departments as well as their field-level functionaries and MY Bharat volunteers

From page 1

EC orders

before and after SIR to identify people whose names were present earlier but disappeared from the final lists. They will then conduct house-to-house verification, particularly in cases where voters are not mapped elsewhere, are not duplicates and have not been reported deceased. BLOs have been assigned a target of covering 20 to 25 electors a week, with the exercise expected to be completed in about a month. Eligible voters identified during the visits will be assisted in filling out Form 6.

The lists prepared during the exercise will also be shared with Booth Level Agents of recognised political parties, according to the Commission's instructions, allowing parties to assist in the verification process. The poll body has said the exercise is intended to provide a route back into the rolls for eligible citizens who were inadvertently left out, while also facilitating the registration of first-time and young voters. The decision comes against the backdrop of political criticism of the SIR. Opposition parties have accused the Commission of working in tandem with the BJP and of disenfranchising eligible voters through the revision. Data shared by the poll authority and state officials showed that the combined rolls of nine states and three Union Territories had shrunk by 10.2 per cent following the exercise, with more than 60 lakh names of deceased voters removed. The Commission has maintained that the deletions were part of the verification process.

Goa has emerged as one example of the difficulties involved in restoring names after the revision. According to an Indian Express report cited in the material, 649 voters flagged for logical discrepancies submitted documents and objections, and electoral officials subsequently found 97 eligible for inclusion. The Goa CEO sent eight communications between February 11 and 17 seeking a mechanism to reverse their deletions, but the final roll published on February 21 did not contain their names. Of those 97 cases, six people were abroad and three held Portuguese passports, while 88 have since been enrolled, according to figures provided by the Goa CEO.

The question of control over the electoral database has also featured in the controversy. Election Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi had raised objections over aspects of the Commission's functioning, including changes to Form 6 and centralised control of ECINet, the software used for electoral rolls. Sandhu had questioned whether statutory election officials retained adequate access to the database, while Joshi had called for an audit of what he described as the gradual centralisation of the electoral roll database. The Commission has said decisions relating to SIR were taken unanimously.

The special drives will now give eligible voters left out during or after SIR a formal route to seek inclusion, while putting the onus on field officials to identify omissions and assist applicants in completing the enrolment process.

700 detained

of India (DYFI), NSUI and other political and student organisations. Former Delhi chief minister Atishi, AAP leader Saurabh Bharadwaj, AISA national president Neha Bora, RJD leader Manoj Jha, AAP's Rajya Sabha MP Sanjay Singh and political activist Yogendra Yadav were among those detained.

Police had denied permission for the proposed October 2 gathering and imposed restrictions under Section 163 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS) in the New Delhi district. Heavy barricading was put up on roads leading to Jantar Mantar, with Delhi Police and Central Armed Police Forces personnel deployed at several points. Several protesters attempting to reach the protest site from the Ashoka Road side were stopped and taken away in buses. Bharadwaj was detained from Jantar Mantar, while Atishi was also taken into custody. In a post on X, Atishi said, "Detained by Modi ji's Delhi Police from Jantar Mantar," and added that the "fight against #VoteChori shall go on", using the hashtag #ChunavAyogThikKaro.

AAP had separately called for a protest and urged people to join the mobilisation on Gandhi Jayanti. SFI and DYFI members also gathered against the Election Commission and the SIR exercise, with the organisations planning to mobilise around 1,500 people at Jantar Mantar.

NSUI workers led by national president Vinod Jhakhar marched towards Jantar Mantar but were stopped by police and multiple barricades. Around 200 workers raised the slogan, "Gyanesh Kumar Go Back". Police later announced that the gathering was unauthorised and warned protesters that action could be taken if they did not leave the area.

IYC president Uday Bhanu Chib led the demonstration, with the youth wing of the Congress announcing plans to gherao the Election Commission's (EC) office.

"We are protesting because the EC is responsible for protecting the sanctity of every vote. When questions are being raised within the commission itself over decisions concerning the electoral roll, the country deserves answers and accountability," Chib said.

AAP's Rajya Sabha MP Sanjay Singh was stopped at North Avenue while he was on his way to the protest. He later said he was sitting on a dharna in front of the Mahatma Gandhi statue on the Parliament premises against "vote theft".

Manoj Jha of RJD questioned whether holding a peaceful demonstration has become a crime, saying he was detained while participating in the protest against the CEC on Gandhi Jayanti. The security arrangements had a wider impact on movement in central Delhi. Mobile internet services were suspended from 9 am to 9 pm within approximately 1.5 km. Delhi Metro Rail Corporation initially announced closure of entry and exit at 11 stations, with Barakhamba subsequently added, taking the total to 12. The affected stations were Janpath, Patel Chowk, Central Secretariat, Rajiv Chowk, Seva Teerth, Mandi House, Lok Kalyan Marg, INA, Chawri Bazar, Ramakrishna Ashram Marg, New Delhi and Barakhamba. Interchange facilities remained available at some stations.

Delhi Traffic Police also imposed diversions and restrictions around Connaught Place, Patel Chowk, GPO, Tolstoy Marg, Jantar Mantar Road, Parliament Street and Ashoka Road. Security personnel were deployed at several points, including Minto Road and roads approaching central Delhi. Barricades were also placed on the DND carriageway towards Delhi, where vehicles were stopped and occupants questioned about their destinations, resulting in slower movement on some stretches.

The protests are part of a continuing political and public debate over the functioning of the Election Commission and the SIR exercise. Opposition groups have alleged that the revision has resulted in the exclusion of eligible voters. The Election Commission has maintained that decisions of the three-member commission, including those relating to SIR, were taken unanimously.

The controversy intensified following an Indian Express investigative report alleging that Election Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi had raised objections on several occasions regarding decisions taken by Gyanesh Kumar without their knowledge. The Election Commission has maintained that decisions concerning SIR were unanimous.

AISA president Neha Bora said the Delhi protest should be seen as part of a wider demand for accountability. "The demand for accountability is a wildfire spreading across the country and people will no longer be silenced," she said, adding that the issue was not limited to the demand for Kumar's resignation but also concerned broader changes in the political system.

Bora alleged that the SIR exercise had affected voters and weakened public trust in the electoral system. "The man bulldozing the SIR is none other than Gyanesh Kumar, and Friday we are going to be demanding that he be impeached and arrested," she said. She also claimed that the issue was part of a wider political exercise, while acknowledging that protesters believed Kumar was acting on directions from higher levels. The October 2 mobilisation follows earlier demonstrations over the SIR exercise during which activists and student leaders were detained. The latest protests brought the electoral-roll revision, voter inclusion and accountability of election authorities back into focus, while security restrictions around Jantar Mantar affected transport and communications across parts of central Delhi.

Mumbai protest

spread to other cities and warned of "Jantar Mantar 2.0" if Kumar did not resign. "If Gyanesh Kumar does not resign, the Gen Z of the entire nation will go to Delhi," he said, while calling for a "Chalo Delhi" campaign. CJP leader Ajinkya Shinde demanded Kumar's resignation and criminal proceedings, besides seeking the freezing of the 2025 voter lists and repeal of the 2023 law governing the appointment of Election Commissioners.

The party has based its campaign partly on reports that Election Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi had raised objections on at least 14 occasions over 10 months concerning decisions and orders linked to the SIR exercise. The Election Commission, however, said decisions of the three-member body, including those relating to SIR, were taken unanimously.

Dipke also made several allegations about voter deletions and changes to electoral rolls, claiming that 13 crore voters had been deleted over two years. He alleged that voter deletions affected election outcomes in Maharashtra, Delhi, Tamil Nadu and West Bengal, and accused the BJP of seeking to weaken regional parties. These claims were made by the CJP and were not established as facts in the material available.

The protest began taking shape hours before its scheduled 4 pm start, with youths gathering around the park and police restricting vehicle movement near Sena Bhavan. Additional personnel were deployed at Dadar railway station by the Government Railway Police and Railway Protection Force.

Protesters carried tricolours and placards reading "Gyanesh BRO, JUST RESIGN" and "Gaddaar Gyaanu Must Go". SFI activists joined the gathering, while AISF-linked groups from Pune played musical instruments and led chants including "Chale Jao", "Vapas Do" and "Band Karo". Songs from Rang De Basanti and A R Rahman's Vande Mataram were also played.

The Gandhi Jayanti setting shaped the stage, which carried messages on non-violence and simplicity along with tributes to Babasaheb Ambedkar. Manish Mandal, a student from Sion, wore jewellery made from Melody chocolate wrappers and carried a banner describing Kumar as "Fraud detergent powder".

Shiv Sena (UBT) extended support to the agitation. Its local MLA Mahesh Sawant said party leader Aaditya Thackeray was absent because he was unwell. CJP leader Saurav Das also criticised the Delhi Police over detentions during protests in the capital.

Modi praises

Recounting the incident to Modi, Machchhar said he was repeatedly beaten and seriously injured but realised he had to act when he sensed that the aircraft was descending.

"I was fighting for my life, but I was determined not to let others die," he said.

Machchhar said he eventually managed to open the cockpit door despite his injuries, after which passengers and crew entered and helped overpower the co-pilot. He said everyone who intervened played an important role in bringing the situation under control.

"I was acting out of survival, yet at the same time, I knew I couldn't let all of them die," he said.

The pilot did not disclose what triggered the attack or what motivated the co-pilot. Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu had earlier said an Israeli passenger told him that the aircraft went into a spin and began descending before a passenger and crew member entered the cockpit and helped overpower the attacker.

Modi praised Machchhar's presence of mind and composure, saying his split-second decision had saved the lives of those aboard the aircraft. He said the episode had also protected the reputation of Indian pilots. "After this incident, the country can proudly say that Indians are not those who take lives, but those who are willing to risk their lives to save others," Modi said.

"Had this not happened, who knows what India would have had to face, what all Indian pilots would have had to endure, and how Indian pilots would have been viewed. You have saved everyone. You have done a very big thing," PM Modi told Machchhar.

The conversation turned emotional when Machchhar told Modi that he considered him his biggest role model. "Getting your call makes me feel so proud. Now I feel proud of myself; until now I wasn't," he said before becoming emotional.

Machchhar also spoke about how he relied on the Hanuman Chalisa during the ordeal. He said he recites it whenever he faces difficulty and was doing so while injured.

"I am away from the country, not from our culture," he told Modi.

The pilot said his two-year-old son sits with him during his morning prayers and that he recites the Hanuman Chalisa to him. Modi told Machchhar that temples across India had conducted prayers for his recovery and that many people were reciting the Mahamrityunjaya Mantra. "You are a brave man. India is waiting to welcome you," he said.

Machchhar said he was receiving good treatment at the hospital and was confident of recovering fully. Rather than viewing his injuries simply as wounds, he said he was treating recovery as a gradual journey.

"I am viewing it as a journey that will happen slowly, step by step, and will take time," he said.

Modi also referred to Machchhar's mother, Geeta Ben, saying she had raised him with the values of the Bhagavad Gita. He thanked the governments of Saudi Arabia and the UAE for caring for the injured pilot and briefly spoke to him in Gujarati.

Referring to Gandhi Jayanti, Modi told Machchhar that he had shown the world the meaning of non-violence through his actions. He later described the conversation as "an unforgettable conversation with Captain Smit, filled with pride and emotions".

Investigations into the cockpit attack and the co-pilot's alleged attempt to interfere with the aircraft's operation are continuing.

Ladakh sites

Indian and Chinese troops during the 2020 eastern Ladakh standoff. The confrontation began on May 5, 2020, after a violent clash near Pangong Lake. Disengagement between the two sides began in 2022.

The other locations include Alisha Giri, Brangsa, Chapchingal Pass, Kanishka Peak, Karun Pir, Kuksel, Martand Giri, Parpik Glacier, Skamri Glacier, Shachmirik Pass, Shkorga Valley and Zorawar Peak.

The list also covers Dehra Compass, Drak Karpo, Jolmori, Kumarayana Point, Panglung, Rinchen Zangpo, Sakyasri Giri, Guru Rinpoche, Shamal Lungpa, Yangpa River, Marpa Lotsava Ri, Milarepa Kangri, Shiva Ri and Maheshwara Ri.

Gold

defence and the goalkeeping of Bichu Devi that carried them through China's sustained pressure as the hosts refused to surrender their slender advantage. The victory completed India's first women's hockey gold at the Asian Games since 1982, after silver-medal finishes in 1998 and 2018, and delivered a major target for coach Sjoerd Marijne's side.

The final itself began an hour late after the team buses of both finalists were caught in a traffic jam caused by an unrelated accident. Once play began, India quickly showed their intent. Sakshi Rana found Lalremsiami inside the circle with a well-placed pass, and the forward unleashed a fierce reverse-stick hit on the run that flew into the upper netting.

China, silver medallists at the Paris Olympics, had more possession for long periods, but India's compact defence repeatedly denied them clear opportunities. India had already been forced to defend with 10 players after Baljeet Kaur received a green card in the sixth minute. They survived the spell without conceding and remained dangerous on the counter.

China's pressure grew in the second quarter. They earned their first penalty corner in the 18th minute, but India's defence intercepted the variation. Six minutes later, China received a penalty stroke after Lalremsiami was penalised for obstructing a forward from behind. India goalkeeper Bichu Devi reacted sharply to keep out the low attempt and preserve the lead.

After the break, China increased the pressure and won a series of penalty corners. India repeatedly threw themselves into the path of shots, with Navneet Kaur producing a crucial goal-line clearance. Captain Salima Tete also intervened several times and was left bleeding after rushing to block an attack.

Ishika Chaudhary, Baljeet Kaur and Sushila Chanu worked constantly to cut passing lanes and disrupt China's forwards. Whenever China managed to get through, Bichu Devi remained composed. With five minutes left, China removed their goalkeeper and committed all 11 players to attack, but India held firm until the final whistle.

The hockey triumph came at the end of a remarkable day for India, who won six gold medals to move to 76 medals overall, including 16 gold, 25 silver and 35 bronze. India moved into sole fifth place, with more total medals than fourth-placed Uzbekistan, which had 65, but four fewer golds.

The women's recurve archery team opened the day's gold rush by beating 10-time Olympic champions South Korea 5-3. Ankita Bhakat, Kirti Sharma and 17-year-old Kumkum Mohod kept their composure in windy conditions to secure India's first Asian Games gold in the event. Kumkum later combined with Dhiraj Bommadevara for a silver in mixed recurve, while India's men's recurve team also took silver after losing to South Korea.

Boxing produced three more gold medals. Lovlina Borgohain, celebrating her 29th birthday, defeated China's Ziyi Bao 5-0 in the 75kg final. Parveen Hooda edged Paris Olympic bronze-medallist Chen Nien-chin of Chinese Taipei 3-2 in the 65kg final, while Ankush Panghal defeated his opponent in the 80kg category to become the first Indian male boxer since Amit Panghal in 2018 to win Asian Games gold.

The three victories gave India their best Asian Games boxing performance in terms of gold medals, with six medals overall. Priya Ghanghas, Kapil Pokhariya and Narender Berwal added bronze medals.

Wrestler Sujeet Kalkal completed another dramatic gold-medal performance in the men's 65kg category. After beating Olympic champion Kotaro Kiyooka 3-3 on criteria in the semifinals, Sujeet recovered from a 2-9 deficit against Tajikistan's Abdulmazhid Kudiev in the final to win 10-9, scoring eight consecutive points before defending his lead in the closing seconds.

The late surge has strengthened India's campaign after disappointing results in some disciplines, including shooting and badminton. With one day of competition remaining, the hockey gold and Olympic qualification provided the most significant breakthrough of the day.

Briefs

Pawar tours drought-hit areas

PUNE: Nationalist Congress Party (SP) chief Sharad Pawar on Friday began a tour of Maharashtra's drought-affected regions, assuring farmers that he would take up their woes regarding crop losses and severe water shortages with the state govt.

The former Union minister interacted with villagers in Purandar tehsil of Pune district to assess crop damage and water scarcity.

Jammu: 100 youths join BJP

JAMMU: Hundred youths joined the BJP at its headquarters here on Friday. Jammu and Kashmir BJP president Sat Sharma welcomed the new entrants and said their participation would strengthen the organisation.

The joining programme was facilitated by Bharatiya Jana Yuva Morcha's (BJYM) Jammu and Kashmir president Arun Prabhat, while the new entrants were led by Deepak Charak.

Bypolls: TN CM holds roadshow

MADURANTAKAM: Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay on Friday held a roadshow here seeking votes for his party's nominee Maragatham Kumaravel for the bypolls to be held on October 6 for the Madurantakam Assembly Constituency.

The CM covered over 30 villages and a cluster of neighbourhoods.

Birla: Draw inspiration from Gandhi

NEW DELHI: Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla on Friday urged youth to draw inspiration from Mahatma Gandhi and Lal Bahadur Shastri, particularly their ideals, public service and commitment to the nation.

Gandhi's life demonstrated the power of truth, morality, nonviolence and Satyagraha, Birla said.

The Lok Sabha speaker was addressing students from across the country who are participating in the 'Know Your Leader' programme.

'RS polls time for coming together'

LUCKNOW: Hinting of a possible patch-up with those who had left the party, Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav on Friday said that the Rajya Sabha elections is "the time for coming together" and "stand united with others on matters of principle".

His remark assume significance, as SP leaders have been saying that the party will field three candidates in the ongoing RS polls, thereby triggering the possibility of cross-voting.

PROTEST SITE WAS HEAVILY BARRICADED

Oppn, activists slam govt over police action on Gandhi Jayanti

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, October 2

Opposition leaders and activists denounced the government on Friday, Gandhi Jayanti, after they were detained at Jantar Mantar for protesting against Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar and the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) exercise, even as they wondered why they needed permission for a peaceful demonstration.

Police cited prohibitory orders to bar the leaders from agitating against the top poll official, who has been besieged with allegations of partisanship and undermining the electorate by deleting lakhs of voters.

RJD leader Manoj Jha, CPI(M) leader Brinda Karat, CPI national secretary P Sandosh Kumar MP, CPI Delhi secretary Prof Dinesh Varshney, AISF general secretary Dinesh Seerangara, and social activists Yogendra Yadav and Nikhil Dey were among those detained.

The protest site and the roads leading to it were heavily barricaded.

The irony of police action against protesters on the peacenik's birth anniversary was not lost on Jha, who was taken to the Badarpur Border area of Delhi.

"Today is Gandhi Jayanti... It is shameful that they are behaving like this..." Jha said as he was dragged inside a bus.

"This is all 'Godse-vadi' people can do on Gandhi Jayanti. They don't understand the essence of Gandhi," he said earlier while the melee was still on.

Asked about permission for the protest, he said, "Protest with permission... in Gandhi's country?"

Brinda Karat, who came to the spot with scores of her party's youth wing workers, said every street in Delhi has become Jantar Mantar.

"Godse was Gandhi's murderer. People of Godse's ideology are in power in the Centre. Today they are murdering democracy through vote theft," she said.

"Around 13 crore citizens have been removed from the voter roll. Gyanesh Kumar should resign; the law for appointment of election commissioners should be changed.

"Today every street, every police bus is Jantar Mantar," Karat said.

Yadav rued that India today is the same as it was under the British.

"There is no freedom of speech ... We demand the impeachment of Chief Election 'Culprit' Gyanesh Kumar on behalf of the people of India," he said.

Dey said "satyagraha" was murdered on Gandhi Jayanti.



Police personnel detain an activist during a protest organised by various student bodies demanding the resignation of CEC, in New Delhi, Friday PTI

HIGHLIGHTS

- Police cited prohibitory orders to bar the leaders from agitating against the top poll official
- 'Godse was Gandhi's murderer. People of Godse's ideology are in power in the Centre. Today they are murdering democracy through vote theft'

Hockey legend Pargat Singh appointed Punjab Cong chief

'The party appreciates the contributions of the outgoing PCC chief Amarinder Singh Raja Warring'

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, October 2

The Congress on Friday appointed Pargat Singh the president of the Punjab Pradesh Congress Committee after Amarinder Singh Raja Warring submitted his resignation earlier in the day.

The appointment came days after the party leadership replaced its AICC in-charge Bhupesh Baghel with Sachin Pilot ahead of Assembly polls due in the state early next year.

Earlier in the day, Warring met Rahul Gandhi and submitted his resignation.

The replacement became necessary as infighting gripped the state unit ahead of elections, with a section of the state leadership not happy with Warring continuing as state unit chief. He has been there since 2022.



Pargat Singh

Pargat Singh is a former Indian Hockey captain who led the Indian team in the 1992 and 1996 Olympics.

Pargat made his political entry with the Shiromani Akali Dal, but later switched to the Congress. He became an MLA from Jalandhar Cantonment in 2017.

"Congress president has appointed Shri Pargat Singh as the President of the Punjab Pradesh Congress Committee, with immediate effect," a statement from AICC general secretary Organisation K C Venugopal said.

"The party appreciates the contributions of the outgoing PCC President Amarinder Singh Raja Warring," the statement also said.

"The Working Presidents and Chairpersons & Co-Chairpersons of various election related committees in Punjab, to continue as earlier," Venugopal said.

PARGAT MADE HIS POLITICAL ENTRY WITH THE SHIROMANI AKALI DAL, BUT LATER SWITCHED TO THE CONGRESS. HE BECAME AN MLA FROM JALANDHAR CANTONMENT IN 2017

Aradhana Misra Mona replaces Ajay Rai as president of Cong's UP unit

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, October 2

The Congress on Friday appointed Aradhana Misra Mona as the president of its Uttar Pradesh unit and named MP Imran Masood as the working president, effecting a major organisational reshuffle ahead of the Assembly polls in the state next year.

Mona, daughter of Rajya Sabha MP Pramod Tewari, replaces Ajay Rai, who has been the Uttar Pradesh Congress president since August 2023. The party also named Chaudhary Virendra Singh as the Leader of the Congress Legislature Party (CLP) in Uttar Pradesh. Mona was the CLP leader until now.

Devinder Nishad and Alok Prasad have been appointed senior vice presidents of the Uttar Pradesh Congress Committee (UPCC), according to a party statement. Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge has appointed the president, working president and senior vice presidents of the UPCC with immediate effect, it said.

The party appreciates the contributions of the outgoing PCC President Ajay Rai, statement said.

SIR, VOTING RIGHTS ISSUE

SKM to hold 'Village Mahapanchayats'

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, October 2

The fight over electoral rights cannot be left to political parties and activists alone, and must be taken to villages and factory sites as part of a broader mass movement, All India Kisan Sabha leader and Samyukt Kisan Morcha (SKM) member P Krishnaprasad said, as the farmers' body prepares to take up the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) issue at village-level mahapanchayats from Saturday.

The remarks came ahead of the SKM's nationwide village mahapanchayats starting October 3, where the farmers' body plans to bring the SIR issue into discussions that have traditionally centred on agricultural demands, such as a minimum support price for crops, farm debt and land rights.

The meetings will continue till October 23 and are also intended to build grassroots-level mobilisation for the SKM's proposed intensification of its farmers' struggle from November 26.

"Along with the crucial demands in mainstream politics, including the MSP and other farmers' demands, the SIR is also coming up. It is not only a question of protesting for our demands, the right to protest itself is under threat and democratic rights, including the right to vote, are being curtailed," Krishnaprasad told news agency.

The SKM will hold village mahapanchayats across the country from October 3 to October 23, with the meetings expected to discuss the SIR exercise alongside the farmers' long-standing demands, including a legal guarantee on the MSP.

Channi has won, Pilot may be behind ouster: Warring

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, October 2

Cracks in the Punjab Congress came to the fore once again after outgoing state unit chief Amarinder Singh Raja Warring called his departure a victory for former chief minister Charanjit Singh Channi.

Warring also said he learnt that the new AICC general secretary in-charge, Sachin Pilot, wanted him replaced, but he voluntarily relinquished his charge.

Nobody had asked him to resign; he did it of his own accord, he asserted.

Warring headed the state Congress for over four years, and his resignation comes ahead of Assembly polls in the state due early next year.

A longstanding infight in the state unit preceded his resignation, with calls for ouster made by Channi and some other leaders.

Cong accuses EC of 'lying' about ECINet, calls for accountability

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, October 2

The Congress on Friday accused the Election Commission of "lying" about the ECINet portal and violating The Representation of the People Act, as it stressed on accountability for the "violations of the law and the Constitution".

Congress general secretary in-charge Jairam Ramesh said that in its "damage control but actually damage enhancing" press note on September 26, 2026 the Election Commission of India had promised a committee to certify that the legally suspect ECINet "complies with the provisions of the Acts and Rules".

"In reality, this should never have been in doubt at all in the first place if the intentions of the CEC Gyanesh Kumar were honest - which they were not," Ramesh said.

ECINet was launched on January 22, 2026 with much fanfare to "enhance transparency, credibility and public trust", he said.

ECINET WAS LAUNCHED ON JANUARY 22, 2026 WITH MUCH FANFARE TO ENHANCE TRANSPARENCY, CREDIBILITY AND PUBLIC TRUST

The ECI press note of that day assured the country that it "has been developed in strict accordance with the law" and in full compliance with the Constitution of India, the Representation of the People Acts, 1950 and 1951, and Registration of Electors Rules, 1960, he said on X.

"All of this was a lie," the Congress general secretary claimed.

"By restricting access of Electoral Registration Officers (EROs) to the ECINet voter roll system and by overruling EROs in states like Goa, West Bengal and others, the ECI controlled by the CEC has violated The Representation of the People Act, 1950 and the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960," Ramesh said.

Both these laws establish that the ERO has statutory authority over the electoral roll, he said. After the revelations last week, the Maharashtra CEO wrote to the ECI on September 24, 2026 asking for a correction of this illegal state of affairs, Ramesh pointed out.

"Starting today, the INDIA janbandhan, citizens and many civil society organisations will hit the streets across the country demanding accountability for these violations of the law and the Constitution," Ramesh said.

The Congress on Thursday had said the chorus of voices against the capture of the electoral system is getting louder and asserted that citizens will no longer tolerate "vote chori" in any form.

JD(U) deputes Lalan Singh to resolve issues of legislators

OUR CORRESPONDENT
Patna, October 2

The JD(U) has tasked senior leader and Union minister Rajiv Ranjan Singh alias Lalan Singh with resolving the differences between party legislators Anant Kumar and Neeraj Kumar at the earliest, its national working president Sanjay Jha said on Friday.

Anant Kumar Singh virtually revolted against his party on Thursday when he accompanied Jan Suraaj Party's candidate Anuj Singh for filing of nomination papers for Patna Graduates' seat in Bihar legislative council elections. JD(U)'s Neeraj Kumar is seeking re-election from the seat.

The Mokama MLA, who has made no secret of his intent to ensure Neeraj Kumar's defeat in the October 23 polls, also took out a procession in support of the Jan Suraaj Party candidate.

Explaining the rationale behind deputing Lalan Singh to resolve the differences, Jha said Mokama comes under the Munger Lok Sabha constituency that is represented by the Union minister.

Talking to reporters here, Jha said, "The responsibility of resolving the differences between the two leaders has been entrusted to Lalan Singh. The party is aware of whatever is happening between Anant Singh and Neeraj Kumar. Since the matter concerns Lalan Singh's Munger Lok Sabha constituency, he has been tasked with resolving the differences."

Anant Singh, however, has remained defiant. "I do not know what the party line is in this matter. The fact remains that he (Neeraj) has opposed me on so many occasions. I must pay him back in the same coin."

Sikkim: Homes, livelihood sources lost due to landslides

The govt has been planning to permanently move affected families to a new site

OUR CORRESPONDENT
Gangtok, October 2

For the 54 families of Rimbi in Sikkim's Gyalshing district, landslides have taken away not just their homes but also many of their livelihoods, and they are now staring at an uncertain future.

The government has been planning to permanently move the families to a new site, but it will take a few months to be completed, making the plight of the impoverished people worse.

The landslides that hit Rimbi in August and September affected 33 families living there permanently and 14 others staying in rented houses without homes and, in several cases, their farmland, their main source of livelihood.

Seven families from Singlitam have also been affected by the calamity, with the displaced families currently staying at a relief camp set up at the village administrative centre.

"The house is gone, the (agricultural) land is gone; now there is no way to earn," said Rimbi resident Sonam Pinchon Sherpa, summing up the uncertainty faced by families who have lost both their homes and land.

Sherpa said landslides had been occurring in the area since August 14, but the situation became critical after the night of September 24, when large-scale movement of earth forced the evacuation of the village.

Though the administration is providing relief materials and other assistance, those have done little to ease concerns over what lies ahead, he said.



KEY POINTS

- The landslides that hit Rimbi in August and September affected 33 families living there permanently
- Sherpa said landslides had been occurring in the area since Aug 14, but the situation became critical after the night of Sept 24

BILL GETS PRESIDENT'S ASSENT

Gujarat becomes second state after U'khand to enact Uniform Civil Code

MPOST BUREAU
Ahmedabad, October 2

The Gujarat Uniform Civil Code (UCC) Bill 2026 has received the assent of President Droupadi Murmu, paving the way for implementation of the legislation, a notification published in the Gujarat Government Gazette has informed.

Gujarat is now the second state after Uttarakhand to enact a UCC.

The legislation, passed by the BJP-ruled Gujarat Assembly on March 24 after a debate lasting more than seven hours, was published in the extraordinary gazette dated October 1. The notification said the Act received the President's assent on September 17.

The Act seeks to "govern and regulate the laws relating to marriage and divorce, succession, live-in relationship and matters related thereto" and extends to the whole of Gujarat, also applying to residents of Gujarat living outside the state.

The Act, however, specifically excludes members of Scheduled Tribes covered under Article 342 of the Constitution and persons or groups whose customary rights are protected under Part XXI of the Constitution.

The legislation, which provides a common framework for marriage, divorce and succession, besides regulating live-in relationships, prohibits bigamy. It makes monogamy a condition for marriage by stating that neither party should have a spouse living at the time of marriage.

It fixes the minimum marriageable age at 21 years for men and 18 years for women. It also allows marriages to be solemnised according to customary practices, religious beliefs, ceremonies, rites and rituals, and specifically lists practices, including 'Saptapadi', 'Nikah', 'Anand Karaj' and 'Mangal Fera'.

Registration of marriages is mandatory, with parties having to to submit a memorandum for registration within 60 days for marriages solemnised after the commencement of the Code.

The Act provides for a penalty of up to Rs 10,000 for wilfully failing to submit a mandatory registration memorandum.

On divorce, the Code lays down common grounds including adultery, cruelty, desertion for at least two years, conversion and disappearance for seven years. It also provides for divorce by mutual consent where the parties have lived separately for at least one year.

It further says that no marriage can be dissolved except in accordance with its provisions, notwithstanding any personal law, custom or tradition to the contrary. Children of marriages declared null and void are to be treated as legitimate under the Code.

The Code also contains provisions on succession, with the estate of a person dying without a will passing first to specified Class-1 heirs, followed by Class-2 heirs and other relatives.

A significant feature is regulation of live-in relationships, with the legislation making submission of a statement of live-in relationship obligatory for partners living in Gujarat.

Gujarat residents living outside the state may submit such a statement to the Registrar in the area where they ordinarily reside.

Children of a live-in relationship are recognised as legitimate.

In certain cases, information submitted for registration is to be forwarded to the local police station, and where either partner is below 21 years of age, the parents or guardians are to be informed.

When the Bill was passed by the Assembly in March, Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel had described its key provisions as "mandatory registration of marriages, registration of live-in relationships, uniform rules for divorce, equal inheritance rights for daughters and sons, and strict enforcement along with penalty provisions for non-compliance".



Gujarat Assembly FILE PIC

HIGHLIGHTS

- The legislation, passed by the state Assembly on March 24 after a debate lasting more than seven hours, was published in the extraordinary gazette dated October 1
- The notification said the Act received the President's assent on September 17

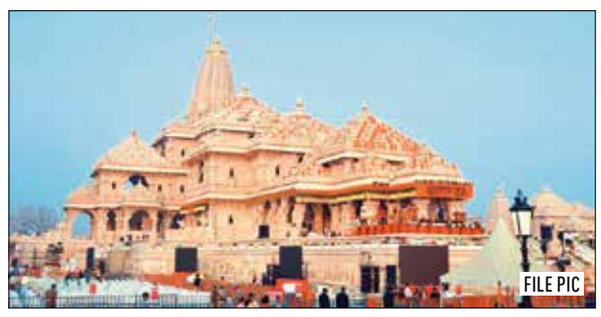
Ram Temple tightens donation security, staff to wear pocketless saffron uniforms

Three-tier security arrangement introduced at entrance to counting room

BISWAJEET BANERJEE
Ayodhya, October 2

The Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust has tightened security and cash-handling procedures at the Ram temple in Ayodhya, introducing pocketless saffron uniforms for employees involved in counting offerings and imposing stricter restrictions on mobile phones and movement in sensitive areas.

The measures are aimed at strengthening internal security, ensuring accountability and preventing unauthorised handling of donations. Employees engaged in counting offerings will now wear a prescribed one-piece saffron uniform without pockets and undergo security checks every time they enter or leave the counting room.



FILE PIC

The counting is conducted in two shifts and involves 36 personnel, including 10 from the temple trust, four temple employees and 22 from an outsourced agency. Workers sit on the floor in the prescribed uniform during the process. Officials said there was no earlier specified dress code for staff involved in counting. A three-tier security arrangement has been introduced at the entrance to the counting room. CCTV cameras have also been installed inside and around the facility, with officials directed to ensure continuous functioning.

The measures follow directions from the trust's new CEO, retired Air Marshal Jitendra Mishra, to clearly define employee responsibilities and fix accountability for lapses.

The trust has also revised guidelines for priests. Under the new dress code, priests must wear a yellow silk achala and uttariya with a dhoti, replacing the earlier chaubandi attire. The dress code was introduced during Janmashtami.

Priests have been barred from carrying mobile phones into the sanctum and advised against making social media statements about the temple that could create misleading impressions. They have also been directed to remain at designated places, maintain courteous behaviour with devotees and inform the shift in-charge before leaving their assigned locations.

Unnecessary conversations, group discussions and joking during service have been discouraged, while priests have been told to remain calm during incidents and seek guidance from designated officials when required.

Punjab CM approves de-addiction programme for 3 border districts

MPOST BUREAU
Chandigarh, October 2

Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann on Friday gave in-principle approval for a pilot project to strengthen psychosocial care for people battling drug addiction alongside medical treatment in the border districts of Amritsar, Tarn Taran and Fazilka.

The decision was taken during a meeting between Mann and a delegation of the Art of Living Foundation, an official statement said.

Mann said the Art of Living-based spiritual wellness programme would bridge the gap between medication-based treatment and sustained psychosocial rehabilitation. He said retaining patients in treatment during the initial months remained a major challenge and stressed the need to strengthen their mental resolve alongside medication.

The pilot will cover outpatient opioid-assisted treatment clinics and jails in Gurdaspur and Kapurthala. Trained local personnel will gradually take over its implementation to ensure sustained operation without dependence on external support.

Mann said the fight against drugs must extend beyond legal enforcement to rehabilitation, relapse prevention, community participation and long-term recovery.

HP Governor Gupta joins war against drugs

ASHWANI SHARMA
Shimla, October 2

Himachal Pradesh Governor Kavinder Gupta on Friday said the growing drug menace was no longer merely a law-and-order issue but a serious social and health challenge requiring collective action from society.

Launching the 'Sankalp Rath Yatra', an anti-drug awareness campaign organised by Utishtha Bharat Sewa Trust at Kasauli in Solan district, Gupta said drug-related cases were cutting across social and professional backgrounds.

In the past two years, 123 government servants have been found involved in drug-related cases, of whom 31, including 21 policemen, have been dismissed from service.

Gupta said the increasing reach of narcotics into communities, workplaces and the lives of young people was a matter of serious concern. He urged parents and teachers to remain alert to behavioural changes among children, listen to them patiently and provide family support.

The Governor said Kasauli should be known for its tourism, natural beauty and military heritage rather than drugs, calling for greater vigilance in tourist and border-connected areas.

He said the response must combine strict action against traffickers and organised crime with treatment, rehabilitation and social reintegration. Drug trafficking could also involve cross-border networks, making it an internal security concern, he said.

Briefs

Hry: Hooda alleges BJP-EC collusion

CHANDIGARH: Former Haryana CM Bhupinder Singh Hooda on Friday questioned why the BJP responds whenever Congress raises issues with the Election Commission, alleging a "deep collusion" between the ruling party and the poll panel. He also accused the government of neglecting Haryana's water rights and failing to check rising debt and inflation.

TDI Group under ED scanner

NEW DELHI: The ED has searched premises linked to TDI Group chairman and managing director Ravinder Taneja in connection with its money laundering probe into the alleged Gurgaon-Manesar land scam. The September 28 searches covered Delhi and S.A.S. Nagar and continued for over three days.

Minor raped in J'khand

RANCHI: A 24-year-old man was arrested for allegedly raping a 15-year-old Class 9 student in Jharkhand's Ranchi district, police said on Friday. The incident occurred on September 29 when the girl was alone at her home in a village under Burmu police station. A case was registered on her mother's complaint under the BNS and POCSO Act.

Saini: Grievance resolved only when citizen confirms

MPOST BUREAU
Chandigarh, October 2

Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Friday said a public grievance would be considered resolved only after the concerned citizen confirms that the problem has been addressed and relief provided.

Reviewing development works, citizen facilities and grievance redressal in Gurugram, Saini said the government had a parallel mechanism to track complaints and obtain ground-level feedback, which he personally monitored.

He said he sometimes spoke directly to complainants, even without identifying himself as the Chief Minister, to understand their concerns and subsequently took up the matter with officials. A complaint, he said, was also a means to assess how effectively government services were reaching citizens.

Saini directed officials to continuously obtain feedback and ordered re-examination of cases where citizens reported that their problems remained unresolved despite disposal reports. Responsibility would be fixed and action taken if negligence was found, he said.

He said officers would be assessed not merely on office-based work but on visible results on the ground, with their performance also reflected in Annual Confidential Reports.

Saini said Regional Officers of the Haryana State Pollution Control Board had been suspended for negligence in the improper operation of a sewage treatment plant by a builder in Gurugram.

He also announced measures including zone-wise areas for ready-mix concrete and conversion of the Gurugram Water Supply Channel into an underground pipeline. The Rs 1,993.59-crore, 69.585-km project from Kakroi Head to Basai Water Treatment Plant is scheduled to begin in January and be completed in 30 months.

Punjab: 2 suspected Pak intruders shot dead by BSF along int'l border

NARESH BISWANI
New Delhi, October 2

THE AUTHORITIES HAVE SO FAR NOT CONFIRMED IF THE TWO MEN WERE INVOLVED IN SMUGGLING NARCOTICS OR ARMS

Two suspected Pakistani infiltrators were shot dead by the Border Security Force after they allegedly tried to enter Indian territory along the international border in Punjab's Tarn Taran district in the early hours of Friday.

The incident occurred near the Rajoke Border Out Post in the Khalra sector of Tarn Taran. Sources said that BSF personnel had spotted some suspicious movement from Pakistani territory at around midnight while keeping vigil on the border.

Further, sources said that a group of suspected infiltrators had been seen trying to enter the country on the India-Pakistan border. The BSF personnel allegedly challenged them when they moved towards Indian territory and opened fire after the men refused to stop.

Two of the men were hit and killed on the spot, while their identity and nationality are yet to be confirmed. A search operation has been initiated by the security agencies to find out if there was anyone else who had crossed over during the incident.

Preliminary reports suggest that a third man might have escaped towards Pakistan, but this is yet to be confirmed.

The bodies have been taken into custody for identification and investigation. The BSF is also looking into if the two men were part of a larger network that was facilitating infiltration and smuggling across the border.

The Tarn Taran sector has been a flashpoint along the Punjab border due to repeated attempts at infiltration and smuggling of arms and narcotics across the border. Security agencies have in recent times beefed up efforts to keep watch on the Punjab frontier through ground surveillance, enhanced patrols and other measures.

The authorities have so far not confirmed if the two men were involved in smuggling narcotics or arms. This will only be established after the search operation is completed and the men's identities are verified.

The incident comes as security forces continue to remain on high alert to prevent infiltration and cross-border crimes along the India-Pakistan border in Punjab. Further details are likely to emerge once the BSF completes its search and identifies the two men who were shot dead.

Bihar: 4 girls drown in pond

MPOST BUREAU
Motihari, October 2

Four girls drowned while bathing in a pond in Bihar's East Champaran district on Friday morning, police said.

The incident occurred around 9.30 am in Bankat village under Paharpur police station. The deceased were identified as sisters Sonawati Kumari (13) and Phoolwati Kumari (10), and Sonali Kumari (10) and Pratibha Kumari (12), all residents of the village.

Paharpur Circle Officer Ramsurat Paswan said five girls had gone to the pond to bathe. While one stayed on the bank, the other four entered the water and reportedly drowned after venturing into deeper waters.

Police recovered all four bodies and sent them to Motihari Sadar Hospital for postmortem, SHO Devendra Kumar said.

'Kochrab Ashram was Gandhi's first laboratory for social change'

'Bapu's decision to house Dalit family at Kochrab sparked local backlash, compelling him to relocate'

MPOST BUREAU
Ahmedabad, October 2

Long before Sabarmati Ashram became the nerve centre of India's freedom movement, Mahatma Gandhi's initial experiments with social justice, equality and self-reliance took root at the colonial-style Kochrab Ashram, Gandhian scholars said on Friday.

Speaking about its historical significance, Gandhi's great-grandson Tushar Gandhi noted that Bapu's decision to house a Dalit family at Kochrab sparked local backlash, ultimately compelling him to relocate across the city to set up Sabarmati Ashram in 1917. While Sabarmati Ashram remains a must-visit site for tourists and dignitaries alike, the "Satyagraha Ashram" at Kochrab in Ahmedabad, founded by Gandhi in May 1915, became the first base for him to put into practice principles of truth, non-violence, simplicity and discipline, and champion the cause of social equality and self-reliance.



FILE PIC

KEY POINTS

- The 'Satyagraha Ashram' at Kochrab in Ahmedabad, founded by Gandhi in May 1915, became the first base for him to put into practice his principles
- During his brief stay at the Satyagraha Ashram, Gandhi began implementing his core ideals — focusing on how to follow them, put them into practice, and integrate them into one's daily life

"It was here that Gandhiji invited a Dalit family to reside, a move that sparked rebellion among many of his associates and led to his social ostracism, eventually compelling him to move to Sabarmati Ashram in June 1917, a little over two years later," said Tushar Gandhi, a noted author and human rights activist.

He said that because of Gandhi's move to invite a Dalit family to stay at Kochrab Ashram, restrictions were imposed preventing them from drawing water from the communal well. "Bapu reasoned that if urban society would not allow them to live according to their principles, they should move to the other side of the city. This led to the establishment of Sabarmati Ashram," he said.

During his brief stay at the Satyagraha Ashram, Gandhi began implementing his core ideals – focusing on how to follow them, put them into practice, and integrate them into one's daily life, said Janak Singh Meena, a professor specialising in Gandhian thought at the Central University of Gujarat.

"From this ashram, Gandhi put the principles of truth, non-violence, simplicity, and discipline into practice, while voicing opposition to untouchability, and championing the cause of social equality and self-reliance, 'Swadeshi' (indigenous self-reliance) and self-sufficiency through the use of the 'takli' (hand spindle) and the 'charkha' (spinning wheel)," he said. A colonial-style building with a white-washed façade, Kochrab Ashram also became the ground for his opposition to untouchability and advocacy for social equality and self-reliance, he said.

The Kochrab Ashram now houses a Gandhi Memorial Museum with a collection of artefacts associated with his life and historical photographs. It has a large portrait of Gandhiji and his wife Kasturba, along with those of Leo Tolstoy, John Ruskin and Shrimad Rajchandra, and some of the historical artefacts on display here are Gandhiji's iconic wooden writing desk and a wooden spinning wheel, 'charkha.'

EDITORIAL

From Complaints To Correction

The Reserve Bank of India's direction to banks to examine the root causes of recurring customer complaints points to a weakness that has become increasingly difficult to overlook. Indian banking has undergone a remarkable technological transformation: payments are instantaneous, accounts can be opened digitally, loans are approved through apps and transactions completed around the clock. Yet when something goes wrong, customers can still find themselves navigating automated responses, repeated escalations and complaints that are technically "resolved" without the underlying problem disappearing. More than 1.33 million complaints were received under the RBI's ombudsman scheme in FY2025, up 13.55 per cent from the previous year. The volume itself should compel banks to look beyond individual cases and ask why the same categories of grievances keep returning.

The RBI is therefore right to emphasise root-cause analysis. A complaint should not merely be treated as an isolated transaction between an unhappy customer and a grievance officer. When hundreds or thousands of customers encounter similar difficulties, the complaint becomes valuable evidence of a systemic weakness. It could point to a poorly designed digital process, inadequate communication, an operational deficiency, inappropriate charges, failures in customer verification or gaps between branches and centralised systems. Closing the individual ticket without correcting that weakness merely ensures that another customer will encounter the same problem. Banks need systems that can aggregate complaints, identify patterns and place recurring failures before senior management. Customer service should be treated as an important source of operational intelligence rather than an administrative obligation.

There is another concern. RBI Deputy Governor Swaminathan J has noted that a significant proportion of complaints eventually decided in favour of customers at the RBI ombudsman level had not first been referred to banks' internal ombudsmen. That weakens a mechanism specifically designed to ensure independent internal scrutiny before dissatisfied customers are forced to seek external intervention. Banks must therefore examine whether classification errors, process deficiencies or institutional incentives are allowing complaints to bypass meaningful review. Accountability should also move beyond simplistic measures such as the number of complaints "closed". Banks should measure how quickly problems are genuinely resolved, how frequently customers reopen complaints, how many decisions are reversed at higher levels and whether corrective action reduces recurrence.

India's banking system increasingly depends on digital interfaces, automated decisions and enormous transaction volumes. That makes effective grievance redressal more important, not less. Technology can help banks detect patterns across millions of complaints, but technology cannot substitute for responsibility. Staff need better training, internal ombudsmen need genuine independence, boards need visibility into recurring grievances and senior executives must be accountable when known deficiencies remain uncorrected. A modern banking system cannot measure efficiency only by transaction speed or app performance. Its credibility is also determined by what happens when the system fails. The real test of grievance redressal is not how quickly a complaint disappears from a dashboard, but whether the problem that caused it disappears too.

LETTER

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Uniform rights

Presidential assent to Gujarat's Uniform Civil Code marks an important development in the debate over common personal laws. Its implementation must protect equality without compromising individual freedoms or cultural diversity. Clear rules, public consultation and safeguards against misuse will be essential to ensure that reform strengthens rights rather than creating fresh disputes.

NEHA SHARMA,
AHMEDABAD

You can also send your comments to The Editor, *Millennium Post*, Pratap Bhawan, 5 Bahadur Shah Zafar Marg, New Delhi 110 002

Making of the Mahatma

From Porbandar to South Africa and India's freedom struggle, Gandhi's journey had transformed truth and non-violence into instruments of change

ENDURING TRUTH



SHAILENDRA BHATIA

THE WRITER IS AN IAS OFFICER



Satyagraha was not merely a political weapon but a moral method

Gandhi is not merely the name of a person; it represents the emergence of a thought, a philosophy, a way of living, a method of struggle, and an embodiment of truth and non-violence.

On 2 October 1869, Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi was born in Porbandar. Little could anyone have imagined that this ordinary child would go on to become a guiding force for an entire age and leave an imprint on world history.

The young Mohandas was deeply influenced by the story of King Harishchandra and the values of truth and sacrifice. The courage to speak the truth, endure difficulties for it, and remain steadfast until the very end became a defining feature of his life. The Bhagavad Gita also deeply influenced Gandhi, particularly its emphasis on performing one's duty with sincerity and remaining committed to one's principles.

Gandhi went to England in 1888 to study law and became a barrister. His years there were also a period of intellectual and spiritual exploration. He read Edwin Arnold's *The Song Celestial,* an English rendering of the Bhagavad Gita, encountered the Bible, particularly the New Testament, and became acquainted with the life of Prophet Muhammad. His exposure to different religious traditions broadened his intellectual horizon.

South African crucible

After returning to India, Gandhi initially wished to establish himself as a lawyer. However, circumstances took him to South Africa in 1893, where he experienced racial discrimination firsthand. The famous incident in which Gandhi, despite possessing a valid first-class railway ticket, was thrown out of a train because of the colour of his skin became a turning point in his life.

South Africa became Gandhi's laboratory of political and social experimentation. Through his experiences there, he developed Satyagraha – the insistence upon truth through non-violent means. For Gandhi, opposing injustice did not mean hatred towards the person committing the injustice; the struggle had to be against injustice itself.

John Ruskin's *Unto This Last* also profoundly influenced him. Gandhi's interpretation of Ruskin's ideas contributed to his philosophy of Sarvodaya – the welfare of all – and strengthened his belief in the dignity of labour, equality and simple living. At the Phoenix Settlement, he experimented with community living and manual labour, gradually developing the conviction that political freedom could not be separated from personal discipline and moral responsibility.

GANDHI'S ENDURING LEGACY LIES IN CONNECTING POLITICAL ACTION WITH MORALITY, DIGNITY AND RESPONSIBILITY

Return to India

When Gandhi returned to India in 1915 at the invitation of his political mentor, Gopal Krishna Gokhale, India was already witnessing several forms of resistance against British rule. Gandhi's arrival gradually provided a unifying framework to these diverse currents.

He travelled extensively across India, attempting to understand the lives, problems and aspirations of ordinary people. The lawyer who had once lived a relatively comfortable life increasingly adopted simplicity. The suit and barrister's attire gave way to simple Indian clothing, while the spinning wheel, khadi, village life, manual labour and self-reliance became important symbols of his public philosophy.

Mobilising a nation

From the Champaran Satyagraha to the Kheda movement, from the Non-Cooperation Movement to the Civil Disobedience Movement, from the Dandi March to the Quit India Movement, Gandhi became associated with several of the most significant phases of India's freedom struggle.

What distinguished Gandhi was his ability to understand the mood of the people, identify an appropriate issue and mobilise mass participation. The Dandi March was perhaps one of the most powerful illustrations of this approach. Salt, which existed freely in nature, became a symbol of resistance against colonial authority. By picking up a handful of salt and breaking the salt law, Gandhi transformed an apparently simple act into a nationwide political movement.

Politics without hatred

Gandhi demonstrated that it was possible to challenge an enormously powerful colonial state through mass participation, civil disobedience, moral courage and non-violent resistance.

At a time when political revolutions in many parts of the world were associated with violence and armed struggle, Gandhi presented an alternative: fight injustice without hatred, resist oppression without violence, and pursue political freedom without abandoning moral principles. Satyagraha was, therefore, not merely a political weapon but a moral method.

Khadi, the spinning wheel, salt, fasting, Satyagraha, Ahimsa and Sarvodaya became symbols through which Gandhi connected self-reliance, moral discipline, resistance and the welfare of all. Through these ideas, political action, personal discipline and social responsibility became interconnected.

An enduring legacy

India's freedom in 1947 was the culmination of a long and complex struggle involving numerous leaders, movements, revolutionaries, organisations and ordinary citizens. Gandhi was one of the central figures in this larger historical process. His greatest contribution may be understood not simply in terms of individual political movements, but in his ability to bring millions of ordinary Indians into the freedom struggle.

His assassination in 1948 brought his physical journey to an end, but the questions he raised about truth, violence, justice, human dignity, economic equality and the relationship between means and ends continued to resonate across the world. After the enormous destruction and violence witnessed during the Second World War, Gandhi's philosophy of non-violence acquired an even wider significance.

Perhaps his greatest relevance lies in this: Gandhi was not merely a leader of his time; his ideas continue to invite every new generation to reflect upon truth, duty, non-violence, human dignity and the means by which society seeks change.

Views expressed are personal

Why are women still unsafe?

A spate of rape cases renews concerns over women's safety as they try to reclaim public spaces

AT VANTAGE



SHUTAPA PAUL

THE WRITER IS AN AUTHOR AND MEDIA ENTREPRENEUR

A few days ago, Soumya Vishwanathan's remembrance was printed in a newspaper. Her family does so every year; a memory of a life well-lived, but also a rude reminder of a life cruelly cut short. For those who aren't familiar, Soumya, a 28-year-old television journalist, was shot in cold blood by hoodlums while returning home from a late-night work shift. This was 2008, and I remember the shock and horror that all of us women journalists felt at the time. We always thought the capital was unsafe, but this blatant act of violence seemed too inscrutable to explain. Some of our friends knew Soumya, some had worked with her, and all raved about her – her end made no sense at all. 18 years on, so little has changed. Women in India continue to fall victim to mindless crimes and acts of violence, and there's no stopping the perpetrators.

On September 21, a 17-year-old minor girl was gang-raped by three men in a park near Kalkaji Mandir in south Delhi, just a couple of kilometres away from the Kalkaji police station. The victim and her male friend were sitting in the park when the rapists, posing as policemen, thrashed and restrained the male friend and went on to brutally rape the girl in the secluded park. I know that locale well, having spent almost three years living right around the corner. My time there coincided with Soumya's murder; it's surreal that both dastardly incidents seem so different and yet so connected. Even back then, the entire area was almost always pitch-black and isolated. Even the road in front of the police station was barely lit. A lack of streetlights has been a niggling issue in Delhi. As per news reports, a safety audit revealed that 33 per cent of 1,525 streetlights in south-east Delhi don't work!

The response from law enforcement has been swift – culprits caught within 12 hours, an audit of 300 parks, deployment of bike patrols, repair of damaged boundary walls, and installation of more CCTVs. The Delhi Development Authority (DDA) proposed restricted entry into parks, curfews, and other directives advising women to keep to well-lit areas. And with that, once again, the burden of staying safe is placed right back on women. A few weeks before the Kalkaji rape, another 17-year-old girl was raped and murdered in Swaroop Nagar, also in Delhi. In the same month, there were reported rapes of another 6-year-old, 11-year-old, and 16-year-old.



The most basic freedom of life continue to be unobtainable

18 YEARS AFTER SOUMYA'S MURDER, WOMEN ARE STILL DEMANDING THE FREEDOM TO MOVE WITHOUT FEAR

As per the latest data from the National Crime Records Bureau (NCRB), India recorded more than 4.41 lakh cases of crimes against women in 2024. Of these, 29,536 were rape cases; these are reported numbers, and the unreported ones could be many more. A woman is raped in India every 18 minutes! In yet another alarming finding, it's also now known that rape cases involving female minors have quadrupled, even though conviction has remained abysmal. In 2015, there were 10,934 girl victims below the age of 18; by 2024, that number had skyrocketed to 43,675. As per reports, 3 lakh girl children were sexually abused in five years.

It's true that women are deemed to be more secure in some cities than others, but then you have a rape inside a hospital in Kolkata, or a teen molestation video emanates from Jamui, or a gang rape happens in Begusarai (both in Bihar), or reports of a campus sexual assault case surface at a university in Punjab, or a 90-year-old woman is gang-raped in Madhya Pradesh. The administration's reaction to lock up, restrict and restrain, sequester and cloak women is now turning old. Because it's not just about surveillance and lighting up streets. There's a deeper rot that runs through the veins of our society, where violence against women has become normalised, and nobody is addressing that. This violence is aimed at stupefying, suppressing and trampling over women's agency, perpetrated by little men who can't stomach their social and financial independence. Ultimately, rapes, sexual assaults, and violence are often less about sexual deviance and more about quelling the spirit of women. So, teach the men about consent and boundaries, educate them about women's empowerment, put curfews on them, and let penal action be swift, harsh, and public. Only then, maybe, some things will change.

For now, the student protests that are reverberating across the national capital feel quite déjà vu. Remember Nirbhaya? The frustration, the hopelessness, the agony of consistently demanding safe public spaces for ourselves is tiring. We have seen it earlier, we have done it earlier, and we are still at it. The most basic freedoms of life and movement continue to be unobtainable manna from heaven for women. We try to reclaim public spaces, we try to express ourselves and live our best lives, but it takes one such barbaric incident of violence to steal our liberty. Our society, our governments, and our male allies are letting this happen over and over again. And women continue to go back and forth like ping-pong balls, once free and then chained again – and thus the sordid cycle continues.

Views expressed are personal

News at a glance

Pak FM: Makkah defence pact committee to meet in Riyadh

ISLAMABAD: A high-level committee of the trilateral Makkah defence alliance, comprising Pakistan, Turkiye and Saudi Arabia, will meet next week in Riyadh to discuss the attacks by Yemen's Houthis on the Gulf Kingdom, Foreign Minister Ishaq Dar said on Friday.

Dar said the foreign ministers of the three countries of the Makkah defence pact, which was signed in August, met on the margins of the United Nations General Assembly in New York last month to discuss the regional security situation.

Russian aerial strikes snarl traffic on 3 Kyiv bridges

KYIV: Russian aerial attacks forced the partial closure on Friday of three bridges over the Dnipro River in Kyiv, the Ukrainian capital's mayor said, in Moscow's latest effort to disrupt life in the city.

Meanwhile, Ukraine's top diplomat said officials have received separate proposals for a partial truce with Russia from the US, India, Turkey and Egypt. The proposals envision halting attacks on energy infrastructure, which have caused fuel shortages in Russia, and on Black Sea shipping needed to get vital grain exports to world markets.



Indian High Commissioner to the UK P Kumaran marks Gandhi Jayanti at Tavistock Square to mark 157th Gandhi Jayanti, in London on Friday PTI

Japan air force starts recovery of crashed Global Hawk drone

TOKYO: Japan's air force said it began recovery operations Friday for a US-made long-distance surveillance drone that had crashed into the sea last month, as the country puts greater emphasis on drones in its defence planning.

The uncrewed RQ-4B aircraft, known as Global Hawk, went missing off the northern coast of Tottori prefecture in northwestern Japan in mid-September. The Japan Air Self-Defence Force said it has determined that the drone had crashed and later spotted what appeared to be the fuselage.

Briefs

Ebola death toll in Congo passes 4,000

BUNIA: Congo's Ebola outbreak has recorded more than 4,000 deaths, authorities said, as they struggle to contain the spread of the virus.

The latest figures released by the Health Ministry on Thursday showed that 4,018 people have died, making up nearly half of the 8,300 confirmed cases, in what has become the fastest-growing Ebola outbreak in history.

Congo announced an outbreak on May 15, caused by the rare Bundibugyo virus, which has no known treatment or vaccine.

Protesters march on Spanish Parl

MADRID: Spain's government looks set to lose two key votes it needs to ratify a package of emergency measures aimed at tackling the nation's housing affordability crisis when lawmakers convened on Friday, while protesters march on the Parliament demanding help for renters.

The Catalan separatist party Junts -- essential for the approval of the two government decrees -- said in a statement Friday morning that it will vote against them. That appears to have doomed the measures when combined with the "No" from the centre-right Popular Party and far-right Vox.

Pak govt speaks with Imran's party

ISLAMABAD: The federal government and leaders of the Pakistan Tehreek-e-Insaf party of jailed former prime minister Imran Khan held talks on Friday to defuse political tensions ahead of the opposition party's planned long march to Islamabad.

The developments come a week after the party announced that its long march to Islamabad would start on October 4, postponing it by a week. The negotiations were being held in the chamber of National Assembly Speaker Sardar Ayaz Sadiq, who is facilitating the dialogue between the two sides.

TRUMP WARNS ISLAMIC REPUBLIC

'Iran will be hit very hard if linked to flydubai assault'

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Jerusalem, October 2

US President Donald Trump said Thursday that if Iran is linked to the copilot who tried to crash an Israel-bound flight, the Islamic Republic would be struck "very hard" for the attempt on the lives of more than 180 people aboard the jet.

Trump issued the warning as investigators worked to determine why the copilot stabbed the flight's captain, causing the FlyDubai plane to plummet before others on board stopped the attack and landed the airliner in Saudi Arabia.

The president was asked by reporters at the White House whether he had been briefed about any links between the pilot behind the attack and Tehran. He said, "We're working on it right now."

"I would say the answer, based on what I'm hearing, is yes, but we're working on it right now," Trump said. He did not elaborate about why he suspects Iran might be involved. Asked if the US would retaliate against Tehran if it was behind the attack, Trump said, "Oh they'll be hit, very hard, don't worry." "You just ask them," he added. "They know what happened. They'll be hit very hard."

His remarks came as diplomatic efforts to end the war appear to have stalled. Iranian officials indicated Wednesday that they received an official US response to Tehran's latest proposal to end the seven-month war, which Trump had publicly rejected just days earlier. The officials did not say what the response contained and whether it was a rejection.



A FlyDubai aircraft carrying Israelis who experienced an emergency landing in Saudi Arabia being seen parked at Ben Gurion International Airport FILE PHOTO

HIGHLIGHTS

- The president was asked by reporters at the White House whether he had been briefed about any links between the pilot behind the attack and Tehran
- Asked if the US would retaliate against Tehran if it was behind the attack, Trump said, 'Oh they'll be hit, very hard, don't worry'

Trump said in a Time magazine interview published Thursday that he will not accept proposals from Iran that "he wouldn't have approved a year ago," and left open the possibility of resuming bombing after the November 3 election in the US.

Meanwhile, the American military has dispatched roughly 9,000 troops aboard a group of ships to the Middle East, a US official said Thursday. That could mean three carriers will be in the region as soon as late October, according to the official, who spoke to The Associated Press on condition of anonymity to discuss sensitive military operations.

Despite Trump's public rebuff, mediators have continued working with Iran and the US to try to broker a deal to end the fighting and open the Strait of Hormuz, according to officials who were not authorised to comment publicly and spoke on condition of anonymity.

UN alarmed after Indian pilot foils alleged flydubai crash bid

The co-pilot was identified as an Omani national

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
United Nations, October 2

UN Secretary-General Antonio Guterres has expressed deep concern over an incident aboard a flydubai flight in which an Indian pilot sustained serious injuries while foiling an alleged attempt by his co-pilot to crash the aircraft.

The Dubai to Tel Aviv flight, carrying 174 people, including 27 children, made an emergency landing at Tabuk in northwest Saudi Arabia on Wednesday following an altercation in the cockpit.

The co-pilot, identified by Israeli officials as an Omani national, stabbed Indian pilot Captain Smit Machchhar and sent the jet plunging nearly 14,000 feet in less than 30 seconds.

Guterres is deeply concerned by the serious incident involving a Tel Aviv-bound flydubai flight and is relieved that tragedy was averted, a statement issued by the Secretary-General's spokesman Stephane Dujarric said Wednesday.



Guterres strongly condemns any act that places at risk civilian lives and the safety of civil aviation, the statement said, adding that the UN chief is grateful to all the authorities concerned for ensuring the safety of all passengers and for conducting their investigation.

"We will continue to monitor all developments related to this incident," the statement said.

The UAE on Thursday said it has opened an investigation and is "closely following" the incident.

Machchhar was stabbed and seriously injured but fought off his co-pilot, who was arrested after the aircraft landed.

India on Thursday said it is keeping a close tab on the health of Machchhar, who was shifted to Abu Dhabi for continued medical care and recovery after receiving initial medical treatment at a hospital in Tabuk.

Saudis plan assault on Houthi rebels

AGENCIES
Riyadh, October 2

Saudi Arabia is planning an offensive against Iran-backed Houthi militants in Yemen, with options being considered including a coastal push to secure the Red Sea shipping route or an assault on multiple fronts, regional and Western officials told Reuters.

The operation, expected to be launched in the coming weeks, will by led by Yemeni forces on the ground, which are overseen by Riyadh, and supported by Saudi air strikes, according to six people with knowledge of the preparations.

Taiwan receives 2 long-delayed US F-16Vs

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Bangkok, October 2

Taiwan on Friday received the first two of 65 F-16V fighter jets ordered from the US, the island's air force said, following years of delays.

The two F-16V Block 70 jets landed at Chihhang Air Base in Taitung. There are 63 more to be delivered. The self-ruled island, which is also claimed by Beijing as part of its territory, placed an order for the F-16Vs in 2019.

Taiwan largely purchases arms from the US, its largest unofficial ally, to boost its defences in the face of a military threat from China. China sends fighter jets and ships toward the island almost daily.

G7 agree to release 100 million barrels of oil, including diesel

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Washington, October 2

The Group of Seven industrial nations said they agreed to release 100 million barrels of oil, starting with "substantial" amounts of diesel after the fuel recently hit record high prices in the United States, where President Donald Trump said the diesel release would happen "immediately."

Trump and his Republican Party face pressure to address surging prices ahead of November's midterm elections.

Trump announced the action Friday on social media, saying, "Europe has just agreed to release a massive amount of their heavily stocked Diesel Oil. The process will begin immediately." The president faces lagging approval ratings as the Iran war and his trade battles have increased US prices for oil and other goods.

Gas prices in the US and abroad have soared during the war, a cost Trump has repeatedly said is worth it for making sure Iran does not obtain nuclear weapons.

US Coast Guard 'intercepted' ship carrying fuel to Cuba

AGENCIES
Washington, October 2

The US Coast Guard said on Friday it had intercepted a large cargo ship carrying fuel bound for Cuba, as the Trump administration's crippling oil embargo against the island nation continued.

The vessel named "Grace" was stopped on September 5 in the Caribbean Sea between Cuba and Mexico while using tactics to evade authorities, the Coast Guard said. The New York Times reported that the ship was 300 feet (91 meters) long.

"Grace was transiting to Cuba, carrying fuel, and was believed to be employing tactics common amongst the dark fleet," the Coast Guard said in a statement. A Coast Guard team boarded the ship and escorted it to Mexico, where a Mexican Navy inspection team "confirmed the presence of large quantities of fuel in the vessel's ballast tanks. The vessel was also carrying several containers believed to contain illicit fuel," the statement said.

Future of Amazon rainforest policies at stake in Brazilian Prez polls

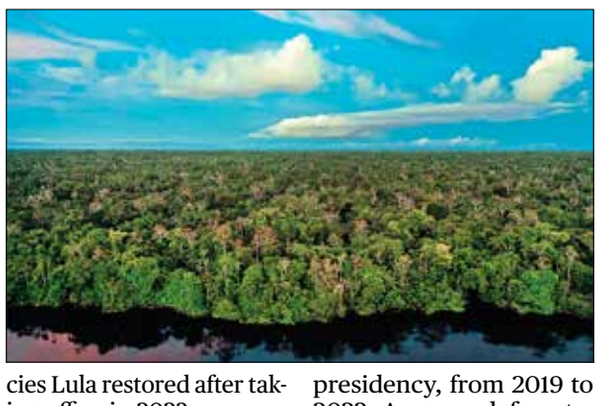
The conservation of the Amazon has been largely absent from this year's election campaign

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Sao Paulo, October 2

Brazil's October presidential election could reshape the future of the Amazon, with the winner leading the country that contains about 60 per cent of the world's largest rainforest -- an ecosystem vital to the global climate.

Heading into the first round of voting on Sunday, the front-runners are Sen. Flavio Bolsonaro, son of former far-right President Jair Bolsonaro, and President Luiz Inacio Lula da Silva, who is seeking a fourth, nonconsecutive term.

The conservation of the Amazon has been largely absent from this year's campaign. Still, the two men represent starkly different visions of how the rainforest should be managed, and climate and conservation experts warn that a victory by Flavio Bolsonaro could reverse the deforestation-control policies Lula restored after taking office in 2023.



KEY POINTS

- During Jair Bolsonaro's presidency, from 2019 to 2022, Amazon deforestation surged by about 60 per cent
- Flavio Bolsonaro has pledged to end illegal deforestation by 2029, a year ahead of Brazil's current targetenvoys

During Jair Bolsonaro's presidency, from 2019 to 2022, Amazon deforestation surged by about 60 per cent, with over 45,000 square kilometres (17,400 square miles) cleared, according to official data. Under Lula, deforestation has fallen 45 per cent, reaching its lowest level in more than a decade. Lula's policies would face resistance from a conservative Congress, where agribusiness holds significant sway. But his plan largely extends an agenda of emissions cuts and financing tropical forests. Flavio Bolsonaro has pledged to end illegal deforestation by 2029, a year ahead of Brazil's current target. Lula's goal goes further: zero net deforestation by 2030, meaning any forest loss, legal or illegal, would have to be offset through restoration.

Deforestation and other land-use changes are Brazil's largest sources of greenhouse gas emissions, which drive global warming.

DECRIMINALISES LICENCE BREACHES

Govt suggests tougher penalties for serious offences in petroleum sector

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, October 2



KEY POINTS

- The Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas has sought public and industry comments on draft amendments to the Petroleum Act, 1934
- Undertaking a licensed petroleum activity without the required licence could attract imprisonment of up to three years, a fine of up to Rs 25 crore, or both

The government has proposed decriminalising regulatory breaches such as violations of petroleum licence terms and introducing a civil-penalty regime, while retaining or strengthening criminal penalties for serious offences involving public safety, critical infrastructure and unauthorised petroleum operations.

The Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas has sought public and industry comments on draft amendments to the Petroleum Act, 1934, proposing a major overhaul of the law's provisions dealing with offences, penalties and enforcement.

The Petroleum Act, 1934, was enacted to consolidate and amend the law relating to the import, transport, storage, production, refining and blending of petroleum.

"It is proposed to amend the Petroleum Act, 1934, through amendment... to achieve the objectives of de-criminalisation of regulatory issues such as breach of terms and conditions of licenses and provides for a mechanism for imposition of civil penalty through an administrative mechanism," the ministry said, seeking comments on the draft amendments.

The proposed amendments "provide adequate deterrence against specific offences relating to various aspects of petroleum operations", it added.

Under the proposed amendments, breaches of licence terms would be dealt with through an administrative adjudication mechanism rather than criminal prosecution. An adjudicating officer could impose a civil penalty of up to Rs 2.5 crore for a first breach and up to Rs 5 crore for a second or subsequent breach.

The adjudicating officer could also direct a licence holder to take or refrain from taking specific actions to prevent or remedy a breach, while recommending suspension, revocation or curtailment of a licence to the licensing authority.

The proposed framework would, however, retain criminal liability where a licensing breach endangers public safety or causes grievous hurt or death, with such proceedings continuing under other applicable laws.

The draft also proposes tougher penalties for several serious offences. Undertaking a licensed petroleum activity without the required licence could attract imprisonment of up to three years, a fine of up to Rs 25 crore, or both.

A continuing violation could attract an additional fine of up to Rs 10 lakh for every day the contravention continues.

Fraudulently or dishonestly obtaining a petroleum licence through misrepresentation or impersonation could attract imprisonment of up to five years, a fine, or both.

Damaging or destroying petroleum facilities, pilfering petroleum or endangering a person's safety could attract imprisonment of up to five years or a fine of up to Rs 15 crore for a first offence. A second or subsequent offence could attract imprisonment of up to seven years or a fine of up to Rs 25 crore.

The draft also proposes imprisonment of up to 10 years for causing damage to designated "critical petroleum infrastructure", along with a fine of up to Rs 25 crore or the cost of the loss, destruction or damage suffered by such infrastructure, whichever is less.

The central government would have the power to notify infrastructure or areas used for petroleum production, import, storage, refining, transportation or blending as critical petroleum infrastructure.

The amendments also provide for penalties for obstructing authorised officers during inspections and failing to report petroleum-related accidents. Repeat violations would attract higher penalties.

For breaches involving false or misleading information in returns, reports, books of account or other documents, the proposed law would provide for civil penalties following an inquiry based on principles of natural justice.

The Act, which governs the import, transport, storage, production, refining and blending of petroleum, was last amended in 1970. Its penalties then were a maximum fine of 1,000 rupees, or one month's simple imprisonment, for a first offence. The ministry said the penalty, though significant in the 1970s, "is now insignificant".

It cites petrol prices rising from Rs 0.90 per litre in 1970 to between Rs 95 and 105 now, and refineries growing from six with 18.4 million tonnes per annum of capacity to 23 with more than 258 million.

'GOBARdhan scheme aims 10-fold CBG output, ₹40K cr import savings'

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, October 2



Petroleum and Natural Gas Minister Hardeep Singh Puri

The Rs 23,731-crore GOBARdhan scheme aims to drive a 10-fold increase in compressed biogas (CBG) production, save more than Rs 40,000 crore in fuel imports, add over Rs 75,000 crore to GDP and create more than 1.5 lakh jobs, as the government seeks to turn agricultural and organic waste into a new source of domestic energy.

Speaking at the formal launch of the scheme, Petroleum and Natural Gas Minister Hardeep Singh Puri said the scheme provides capital assistance, as well as guaranteed offtake of the renewable fuel produced by processing organic waste such as agricultural residue, animal dung, food waste and other biomass.

Capital support plus guaranteed offtake is likely to lift CBG (essentially methane-rich gas) from current 0.4 million standard cubic metres per day to 4-6 mmscmd, he said, hoping this would help in achieving the target of raising share of natural gas - a cleaner-burning, lower-pollution fuel - in India's energy basket to 15 per cent by 2030 from current 6-7 per cent.

The scheme is designed to replace about 10 million tonnes of fossil fuel with clean gas, potentially cutting more than 40 million tonnes of CO2 emissions, while producing around 250 million tonnes of organic manure for farmers.

Puri said the programme would help turn farmers from "Annadatas to also being the Urjadatas".

GOBARdhan - Galvanising Organic Bio-Agro Resources Dhan - will convert agricultural residue, cattle dung, press mud, food waste and segregated biodegradable municipal waste into CBG and organic manure. The CBG can be supplied through city-gas networks for CNG transport and domestic PNG use.

It provides capital assistance of up to Rs 30 crore per CBG project across the two eligible capital-support components. For new greenfield plants, assistance is set at Rs 1.25 crore per tonne per day (TPD) of eligible CBG capacity. Brownfield projects can receive support at 50 per cent of the applicable greenfield rate for additional capacity created through fresh investment.

Existing biogas plants upgraded to produce CBG can receive Rs 0.60 crore per TPD, subject to a Rs 5-crore project ceiling.

To make CBG projects more commercially viable, the government is offering producers assured offtake of up to 100 per cent of eligible output, at an administered price of Rs 2,110 per million British thermal units - equivalent to about Rs 98 per kg. The administered price is set to remain in place until March 2036, providing greater revenue visibility to investors.

City gas distributors will be required to procure CBG for their CNG transport and domestic piped natural gas (PNG) supplies, with the obligation rising from 3 per cent in 2026-27 to 5 per cent from 2028-29. GAIL has been designated as the synchronisation operator responsible for procurement and pooling of CBG.

The country currently consumes about 66 billion cubic metres of gas annually, nearly half of which is imported, while demand is projected to reach 95-100 billion cubic metres by 2030, Puri said.

India also generates about 230 million tonnes of agricultural residue and 62 million tonnes of municipal solid waste each year.

As of August 2026, 1,908 CBG/Bio-CNG plants had been registered, with 217 commissioned and another 339 under construction.

"GOBARdhan creates an opportunity to turn waste into energy," Puri said.

Adani completes projects of ₹2.6L cr in Maha

AGENCIES
Mumbai, October 2



The Adani Group has completed or is executing projects worth Rs 2.6 lakh crore in Maharashtra out of an investment commitment exceeding Rs 6 lakh crore across sectors including energy, aviation, urban regeneration, data centres and coal gasification, a senior group official said.

Speaking at the launch of Maharashtra's investment promotion body 'Invest Maharashtra', Pranav Adani, Director, Adani Enterprises, said the group's investment blueprint was developed through commitments made at the World Economic Forum in Davos and partnerships with the state government.

"Projects worth Rs 2.6 lakh crore are already completed or under execution," he said.

The group's investments include management of Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj International Airport and development of Navi Mumbai International Airport, which is expected to eventually handle over 90 million passengers annually.

Adani Electricity Mumbai supplies power to more than 3 million homes and establishments, with over 60 per cent of its power sourced from renewable energy. The group is also developing a 1,000 MW high-voltage direct-current transmission link for Mumbai and pumped-storage hydro projects across Maharashtra.

On Dharavi redevelopment, Adani said the group was focused on providing modern housing, formalising micro-enterprises and developing the area into an integrated economic hub.

He said Maharashtra's target of becoming a $1 trillion economy by 2030, with the Mumbai Metropolitan Region playing a central role, provided a significant opportunity.

KVIC launches nationwide Khadi discount sale

MPOST BUREAU
New Delhi, October 2



Khadi and Village Industries Commission (KVIC) Chairman Manoj Goyal on Thursday launched a nationwide special discount sale on Khadi and village industry products on the occasion of Gandhi Jayanti.

Goyal purchased Khadi products at Gramodyog Bhawan and Gram Shilpa Emporium in New Delhi's Connaught Place and made payments through UPI. The discount campaign will run from October 2 to November 16, 2026, offering up to 20 per cent discount on Khadi products and 10 per cent on village industry products.

Goyal said KVIC was working to take the 'Har Ghar Swadeshi, Ghar-Ghar Swadeshi' and 'Vocal for Local' messages to the masses and Gen-Z. He said Khadi had become a means to promote Atmanirbhar Bharat, Local to Global and Developed India-2047.

According to Goyal, the Khadi and Village Industries sector recorded turnover of over Rs 1.87 lakh crore in 2025-26 while more than 2.04 crore people are getting employment through this sector.

He expressed confidence of achieving the Rs 2.51 lakh crore turnover target in the coming years.

CORPORATE KALEIDOSCOPE



Rail Coach Factory (RCF), Kapurthala is observing 'Swachhta Hi Seva Abhiyan-2026' from September 17, 2026. The campaign was inaugurated on September 17 by Ajay Nandan, General Manager, RCF, by administering the Swachhta pledge to officers and employees.



Bank of Baroda received the PFRDA Certificate of Appointment as Sponsor of the Pension Fund under Section 27 of the PFRDA Act, 2013. The certificate was presented by Sanjay Lohiya, IAS, Secretary, Department of Financial Services (DFS) to Dr. Debadatta Chand, MD & CEO, Bank of Baroda, in the presence of S Ramann, Chairperson, PFRDA and Dinesh Kumar Khara, Chairperson, NPS Trust.

ICICI Prudential Life appoints Sidharatha Mishra as MD & CEO

MPOST BUREAU
New Delhi, October 2



Sidharatha Mishra

ICICI Prudential Life Insurance on Friday said Sidharatha Mishra has been appointed as the Managing Director and CEO with effect from October 14.

Mishra will succeed Anup Bagchi, who will take over as HDFC Bank MD & CEO with effect from October 27.

In a regulatory filing, ICICI Prudential said its board has noted the resignation of Bagchi as Managing Director and Chief Executive Officer, with effect from close of business hours on October 13, 2026.

Mishra, the filing said, will take charge as the Chief Operating Officer, with effect from October 6.

Thereafter, effective October 14, Mishra will take over as Additional Director and Managing Director & CEO for a period of five years, subject to regulatory approvals.

ICICI Pru Life board also appreciated Bagchi's contribution to the growth and success of ICICI Group over the last three decades across a variety of roles. "During his tenure at ICICI Life, Mr Bagchi has successfully steered the Company to emerge as a resilient franchise," ICICI Life said in a regulatory filing.

India's forex reserves drop $18.343 bn to $747.56 bn: RBI

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Mumbai, October 2

India's forex reserves dropped $18.343 billion to $747.557 billion during the week ended September 25, the Reserve Bank said on Friday.

The reserves had touched an all-time high of $785.706 billion for the week ended September 4 on the back of a heavy flow of currency as part of a special concessional swap for deposits from the diaspora through which banks raised a record sum of over $130 billion.

For the week ended September 25, foreign currency assets, a major component of reserves, decreased by $15.57 billion to $615.411 billion, according to the data released by the Reserve Bank of India (RBI).

The value of gold reserves decreased $2.591 billion to $108.701 billion during the week, the RBI said.

The Special Drawing Rights (SDRs) were down $97 million to $18.642 billion, the apex bank said.

India's reserve position with the International Monetary Fund (IMF) decreased $86 million and stood at $4.804 billion.

OPEC+ delays capacity review crucial for setting 2027 oil quotas

It was due to be completed by the end of September 2026 but is now likely to finish by mid-November

AGENCIES
London/Moscow, October 2



CLOSER LOOK

- US petroleum consultant DeGolyer and MacNaughton is assessing capacity for OPEC+ members except Russia, Iran and Venezuela, which are under US sanctions
- The consultant is expected to submit its report to OPEC by mid-November, allowing the group to consider the findings at its next group-wide meeting in late November

An OPEC+ review to determine members' 2027 oil output quotas has been delayed after the US-Israeli war on Iran disrupted projects aimed at expanding production capacity across the Middle East, creating uncertainty over future output potential, two sources familiar with the matter said.

OPEC+, comprising the Organization of the Petroleum Exporting Countries (OPEC), Russia and other allies, ordered the production capacity review for all members in late 2025 ahead of setting 2027 quotas. The review was due to be completed by the end of September 2026 but is now expected to finish by mid-November, the sources said.

At its last group-wide meeting in June, OPEC affirmed "the importance of completing the maximum sustainable production capacity (MSC) assessment for all (member) countries to be used as reference for 2027 production baselines".

US petroleum consultant DeGolyer and MacNaughton is assessing capacity for OPEC+ members except Russia, Iran and Venezuela, which are under US sanctions, the sources said. The consultant is expected to submit its report to OPEC by mid-November, allowing the group to consider the findings at its next group-wide meeting in late November.

The Middle East conflict has delayed projects that were expected to boost production capacity in some OPEC+ countries, complicating estimates of how much oil they will be able to sustainably produce. Not all countries have submitted the data required for the review, the sources said.

Russian Deputy Prime Minister Alexander Novak was reported by Russian state news agency TASS as saying on Friday that OPEC+ countries continue to assess maximum production capacities.

The review is politically sensitive as capacity estimates are likely to influence individual members' output allocations. Countries with lower assessed capacity could face pressure for lower quotas, while producers that have expanded capacity may seek higher allocations.

The United Arab Emirates, which had pushed for a higher OPEC+ quota to reflect rising production capacity, left the alliance in May.

Iraq is also seeking a higher quota and has considered leaving OPEC, sources told *Reuters* in June.

THIS IS AGAINST UPI VOLUME 114 BN IN H1 OF PREVIOUS FISCAL

UPI volume rises 27% to touch 145 bn in first half of current financial year

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, October 2



UPI transactions through popular Unified Payments Interface (UPI) in volume terms have witnessed a 27 per cent jump to around 145 billion in the first half of the current fiscal year.

This is against UPI volume 114 billion during the April-September, the first half of the previous financial year, according to data released by the National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI).

As regards September, the UPI volume moderated by 1.7 per cent to 24.07 billion as compared to 24.5 billion recorded last month.

On a month-on-month basis, value, too, declined 1.5 per cent to Rs 29.37 lakh crore against Rs 29.82 lakh crore in August.

The figures come a fortnight ahead of the implementation of the new merchant discount rate (MDR) fee on high-value UPI payments for merchants.

Industry watchers attributed the decline to the fact that August has 31 days versus 30 in September, and pointed out that the average transactions per day were higher in September at 802 million versus 791 million in August.

NPCI, an initiative of the RBI and the Indian Banks' Association (IBA), is an umbrella organisation for operating retail payments and settlement systems in India.

It runs the UPI used for real-time payments between peers or at merchants' end while making purchases.

Effective October 15, a 0.4 per cent merchant discount rate will be levied on merchants for UPI transactions over Rs 2,000.

However, no charge will be levied on person-to-person transactions regardless of the amount.

The introduction of a 0.4 per cent MDR on certain UPI transactions above Rs 2,000 is aimed at creating a sustainable revenue framework for the digital payments ecosystem.

The MDR is a fee paid by merchants to payment service providers for processing digital transactions.

The collected amount will be shared among banks and other entities in the UPI ecosystem. Of the total MDR collected, 40 per cent will go to customers' banks, 30 per cent to payment gateway, 20 per cent to the UPI app and the remaining 10 per cent to the sponsoring bank of the UPI app.

It is to be noted that the MDR charge will be paid by merchants, not consumers, and will be capped at Rs 300 for transactions of Rs 75,000 or more. Payments between individuals, as well as the vast majority of everyday merchant payments, will remain free.

Essential services, such as railways, telecom, fuel and insurance, will attract a flat Rs 5 fee per transaction above Rs 2,000. Capital markets transactions (mutual funds, stockbroking) get a lower 0.02 per cent rate, also capped at Rs 300.

Small merchants collecting up to Rs 1 lakh a month via UPI QR codes remain fully exempt from any new charge and shield about 96 per cent of all merchant transactions.

As far as overseas presence is concerned, UPI now is accepted in 11 countries, with Uzbekistan being the latest entry.

The other countries where UPI is accepted are Singapore, the United Arab Emirates, France, Mauritius, Nepal, Bhutan, Qatar, Sri Lanka, Cambodia, and Greece.

The UPI, launched on August 25, 2016, has transformed India's digital payments landscape, with transaction value surging from Rs 0.07 lakh crore in FY17 to around Rs 314 lakh crore in FY26, a more than 4,000-fold increase over the decade.

KEY POINTS

- As regards September, the UPI volume moderated by 1.7 per cent to 24.07 billion as compared to 24.5 billion recorded last month
- It is to be noted that the MDR charge will be paid by merchants, not consumers, and will be capped at Rs 300 for transactions of Rs 75,000 or more

SBI Research sees CPI inflation at 5.65% in Sept, above 6.5% in Oct-Nov

ANI NEWS
New Delhi, October 2



SBI Research expects CPI inflation to rise to around 5.65 per cent in September and cross 6.5 per cent in October and November, before easing below 6 per cent in early 2027.

In its pre-Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) report released on Friday, SBI Research said the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) may raise the policy repo rate by at least 25 basis points at its October 5-7 monetary policy meeting, citing rising inflation, global risks and pressure on the rupee.

"We believe the balance of risks has tilted decisively towards a 25-bps rate hike at this juncture," the report said.

SBI Research said the shift towards a rate hike was driven by broadening inflationary pressures, worsening global macroeconomic conditions, changing liquidity conditions and renewed repricing of risks in global markets.

The current policy repo rate stands at 5.25 per cent. A 25-basis-point hike would mark a shift from the RBI's previous policy stance.

At its August 3-5 meeting, the MPC unanimously kept the repo rate unchanged at 5.25 per cent and retained its neutral stance. The RBI had said it wanted greater clarity on the direction and composition of inflation before taking further policy action.

THE CURRENT POLICY REPO RATE STANDS AT 5.25 PER CENT. A 25-BASIS-POINT HIKE WOULD MARK A SHIFT FROM THE RBI'S PREVIOUS POLICY STANCE

The central bank had projected FY27 GDP growth at 6.7 per cent and CPI inflation at 5 per cent.

According to SBI Research, inflationary pressures have strengthened since the August policy meeting. Retail inflation rose to 4.82 per cent in August from 4.45 per cent in July, with price pressures spreading across a wider range of items.

The report said 22 commodities accounted for 90 per cent of the weighted contribution to CPI inflation in January. By August, the number had increased to 51, indicating that inflationary pressures had become more broad-based.

SBI Research also highlighted weakness in the rupee as a key risk. It attributed the pressure on the currency to a strong US dollar, foreign currency demand from oil marketing companies and corporates, and continued selling by foreign portfolio investors.

The research house also flagged risks from the weak monsoon. The 2026 southwest monsoon stood at 87 per cent of the long-period average, while 43 per cent of districts received deficient rainfall.

SBI Research said strong El Niño conditions and below-normal rainfall in October could pose risks to Rabi crops and add to food inflation pressures.

The research house expects the RBI to raise its FY27 GDP growth forecast by 30 basis points and its inflation projection by 20 basis points at the October policy review.

The RBI's October MPC meeting is scheduled to be held from October 5 to 7.

RBI appoints Sudhakar Malli as new Executive Director



AGENCIES
Mumbai, October 2

The RBI has appointed Sudhakar Malli as Executive Director (ED) with effect from October 1, the central bank said in a statement on Friday.

Before his elevation, Malli was Chief General Manager-in-Charge of the Department of Supervision at RBI. As ED, he will oversee the Department of Supervision (Supervisory Assessment), the central bank said.

Malli is a career central banker with around three decades of experience, including more than two and a half decades in supervising banks, non-banking financial companies (NBFCs) and co-operative banks.

He also has around five years of supervisory experience in overseas jurisdictions and has worked in Currency Management.

Malli holds a B.Tech degree in Mechanical Engineering and is a Certified Associate of the Indian Institute of Bankers (CAIIB).

'Govt absorbing up to ₹2,700/urea bag as global costs rise to ₹3,000'

ANI NEWS
Madanapalle, October 2

The Centre has been absorbing a subsidy of around Rs 2,700 on every bag of urea when global costs have risen as high as Rs 3,000, keeping the price paid by farmers at around Rs 300, Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman said on Friday.

Addressing a gathering at Madanapalle in Andhra Pradesh, Sitharaman said the government had sought to shield farmers from the sharp rise in fertiliser costs caused by global disruptions, including the pandemic and geopolitical tensions in West Asia.

"Despite severe global headwinds, the pandemic and geopolitical strife in West Asia driving import costs up to Rs 3,000 per bag of urea, PM ensured our farmers continued to receive it at just Rs 300, providing a subsidy of Rs 2,700/bag, directly absorbing the global burden," Sitharaman said, according to posts by the Finance Minister's Office on X.

Fertiliser subsidies are used by the government to keep farm input prices below their delivered cost. Under the Urea Subsidy Scheme, the difference between the delivered cost of urea and the amount realised from its sale is reimbursed by the government to fertiliser manufacturers and importers.

The government-notified maximum retail price of a 45-kg bag of urea currently stands at Rs 242, excluding neem-coating charges and applicable taxes. Sitharaman's remarks referred to the farmer price in rounded terms while highlighting the extent to which the Centre has absorbed higher global costs.

The Finance Minister said ensuring adequate availability of essential farm inputs remained a government priority alongside income support and access to institutional credit.

FPIs turn net sellers, pull out ₹35,860 cr in Sept

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi, October 2

After two consecutive months of buying, foreign portfolio investors (FPIs) turned net sellers in September, pulling out Rs 35,860 crore from Indian equities amid global uncertainties, elevated US interest rates and high crude oil prices.

The selling continued into October, with foreign investors pulling out another Rs 9,232 crore from equities on October 1, according to data from Central Depository Services Limited (CDSL).

The outflows came after FPIs invested Rs 20,200 crore in Indian equities in July and Rs 29,630 crore in August.

IN DEBT MARKET, FPIs WITHDREW RS 10,431 CRORE THROUGH THE FULLY ACCESSIBLE ROUTE, RS 5,049 CRORE VIA THE VRR AND RS 5,246 CRORE THROUGH THE GENERAL ROUTE

With the latest selling, FPIs have now withdrawn around Rs 2.7 lakh crore from Indian equities so far in 2026, significantly higher than the Rs 1.66 lakh crore outflow recorded during the entire 2025.

Rajesh Singla, Fund Manager & CEO at Alpha AMC, said FPIs were withdrawing from Indian equities largely due to external factors such as elevated crude prices amid Hormuz-related supply risks, a weak rupee, firm US bond yields, profit-booking following the July-August inflows and rotation towards AI-led North Asian markets.

"This is a global allocation story, not a domestic earnings one," he said.

Singla said domestic SIP flows were helping absorb the impact of foreign selling, while SME and small-cap segments, which have relatively limited FPI ownership, remained comparatively insulated.

"Strategically, India's growth case is intact; capital is rotating, not exiting," he added.

Going ahead, analysts said FPI flows would be influenced by the ongoing Iran-US conflict and its impact on crude oil prices.

Elevated crude prices and higher US bond yields, with the US 10-year yield at around 5 per cent, could weigh on Indian equities and FPI flows.

However, the resilient Indian economy and expectations of stronger earnings growth remain positive factors, they said.

Foreign investors also extended their selling to the debt market during September. They withdrew Rs 10,431 crore through the Fully Accessible Route (FAR), Rs 5,049 crore via the Voluntary Retention Route (VRR) and Rs 5,246 crore through the general route.

Nadda urges life sciences industry to make patient-centric innovation its central mission

MPOST BUREAU
New Delhi, October 2



Union Health Minister Jagat Prakash Nadda urged India's life sciences industry to make patient-centric innovation its central mission as the inaugural Bharat Life Sciences Awards, organised by FICCI and powered by Eli Lilly and Company (India), honoured winners at Vigyan Bhawan.

The awards, backed by Rs 7 crore in grants, received over 500 applications. Dr Vamsee Mallajosula, National Centre for Biological Sciences (TIFR), won the Ramanujan Arogya Udaan Samman for Young Scientist, while Dr Bharti Bhatia, Translational Health Science and Technology Institute, was runner-up.

Pacify Medical Technologies won the Charaka Arogya Samman; Bharat Serums and Vaccines (BSV-Mankind) won the Sushruta Arogya Samman; and BRIC-National Institute of Biomedical Genomics won the Nalanda Arogya Vigyan Samman, with LV Prasad Eye Institute as runner-up.

The Jivaka Arogya Navpravartan Gaurav went to Sciverse Solutions, while Dr Ratnesh Jain, Institute of Chemical Technology, Mumbai Biocluster, received the Sarabhai Arogya Drishti Gaurav.

NITI Aayog Member Prof Gobardhan Das, Pharmaceuticals Secretary Manoj Joshi, and Drugs Controller General of India Dr Rajeev Singh Raghuvanshi also addressed the summit.

Keventer and Poddar Group launch ₹400 cr Category II real estate AIF

MPOST BUREAU
Kolkata, October 2



Mayank Jalan, Chairman & MD, Keventer Group

Kolkata-based Keventer Group and Saroj Poddar Group have launched a Rs 400-crore Category II Alternative Investment Fund (AIF), the first such fund by a West Bengal real estate developer, they said.

The Poddar Keventer Real Estate Fund – Scheme I has a target corpus of Rs 400 crore, with a Rs 200 crore greenshoe option, taking it to Rs 600 crore. The secured real estate debt fund will focus on projects in Delhi-NCR and West Bengal and target a gross IRR of 18-22 per cent before expenses. Sponsors have committed Rs 80 crore.

Mayank Jalan, Chairman & MD, Keventer Group, said, "We see significant opportunities across both Delhi-NCR & West Bengal," driven by consumer aspirations, infrastructure-led development and demand for quality real estate.

Akshay Poddar, Promoter, Saroj Poddar Group, said the AIF ecosystem was increasingly supporting India's growth opportunities, with real estate a key investment destination.

Gaurav Agarwala, Head of Operations, Poddar Keventer, said the fund would combine real estate expertise with disciplined investment and execution.

Surya Narayan Panigrahi takes over as Executive Director (HR), NTPC Ltd

MPOST BUREAU
New Delhi, October 2



Surya Narayan Panigrahi has taken charge as Executive Director (HR) of NTPC Ltd. He earlier served as Executive Director (HR)-cum-Regional Head of HR for NTPC's Northern and Southern Regions.

Panigrahi has over 36 years of experience with NTPC, handling recruitment, training, industrial relations, employee welfare, administration, security, CSR and HR digitalisation.

He has served at major NTPC establishments, including Talcher Kaniha, Vindhyachal, Jhajjar, Tanda and the Corporate Centre. He played a key role in implementing PeopleSoft HRMS and SAP ERP systems and developing integrated security systems.

Devendra Fadnavis inaugurates Dharavi Experience Centre

The centre offers residents a first-hand view of planned homes & commercial spaces

MPOST BUREAU
Mumbai, October 2



Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis on Friday inaugurated a 22,500-square-foot Experience Centre showcasing the proposed redevelopment of Dharavi and offering residents a first-hand view of planned homes, commercial spaces, transport links and public infrastructure.

Inaugurated on Gandhi Jayanti, the centre features life-size models of proposed 350-square-foot rehabilitation homes and 500-square-foot renewal apartments, besides a 3D walkthrough of the planned township.

Fadnavis also unveiled an anthem dedicated to Dharavi and released a coffee-table book celebrating the neighbourhood, one of Asia's largest slums and home to more than one million people.

The Adani Group is redeveloping the 600-acre neighbourhood into an integrated urban district while retaining its link between homes and livelihoods. The project includes rehabilitation housing, upgraded commercial spaces, schools, healthcare facilities, transport infrastructure, parks and open spaces.

It also proposes rejuvenation of the Mithi River, around 40,000 trees and a 3.3-kilometre public riverfront.

The centre uses digital displays and interactive exhibits to explain residential and commercial areas, roads, public transport and community infrastructure. Visitors can walk through furnished and unfurnished apartment models.

Digital and assisted services will provide information on surveys, eligibility, documentation and rehabilitation processes. A proposed Multimodal Transport Hub aims to improve connectivity for residents and other Mumbaikars.

HIGHLIGHTS

- The centre features life-size models of proposed 350-square-foot rehabilitation homes and 500-square-foot renewal apartments
- The Adani Group is redeveloping the 600-acre neighbourhood into an integrated urban district while retaining its link between homes and livelihoods

Briefs

Chahal retires from red-ball format

LONDON: Out-of-favour India leg-spinner Yuzvendra Chahal has announced his retirement from first-class cricket after playing the final English county championship match for Northamptonshire against Middlesex at the hallowed Lord's last month.

Chahal, who has played 72 ODIs and 80 T20Is for India, never fully realised his red-ball potential and played 49 first-class game in which he picked 148 wickets with six five-wicket hauls.

In his final first-class season for the Northants, Chahal took 21 wickets in five games including a nine-wicket match haul against Durham. treatment or vaccine.

Mohsin Naqvi to miss India-Pak final

DUBAI: The Asian Cricket Council president Mohsin Naqvi will not be in attendance during the high-profile Asian Games gold medal contest between India and Pakistan scheduled on Saturday at the Korogi Park in Japan's Nisshin city.

"ACC President, Mr. Mohsin Naqvi, will miss Finals Day at Asian Games 2026 due to prior commitments, but sends his very best wishes to all four teams ahead of the Gold and Bronze Medal Matches," the official media handle of ACC posted on its 'X' handle.

Naqvi, who is the chairman of the Pakistan Cricket Board and also the country's Interior Minister, has been a problematic figure for the BCCI.

Dehradun Warriors lift UPL trophy

DEHRADUN: Dehradun Warriors were crowned champions of the Uttarakhand Premier League (UPL) Season 3 after securing a 36-run victory over Haridwar Elmas in the final here.

The Dehradun side, which had dominated the season, produced an impressive all-round performance in the title clash. Dehradun Warriors had also enjoyed an excellent run during the league stage, winning four of their six matches and finishing at the top of the points table. In the final, Dehradun Warriors captain Kunal Chandela opted to bat first. However, the team did not get off to the best of starts, losing two key wickets with just 22 runs on the board. Despite the early setbacks, Chandela took charge of the innings, combining patience with attacking strokeplay. He smashed a blistering 90 off just 51 balls, with eight fours and four towering sixes.

At the other end, Mohammad Uzair Malik provided excellent support, scoring 64 off 46 balls, including four fours and four sixes.

INDIA FINISHED ATOP MEDALS TALLY

Asian Games: Boxers Lovlina, Parveen, Ankush strike gold

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Nishio, October 2





Indian boxers delivered a sensational hat-trick of gold medals at the Asian Games with Lovlina Borgohain (75kg), Parveen Hooda (65kg) and Ankush Panghal (80kg) producing contrasting but stirring performances in their respective finals here on Friday.

Lovlina and Parveen ended a 12-year wait by joining legendary MC Mary Kom in the select group of Indian women boxers to have won Asian Games gold. The Manipuri had claimed the flyweight (51kg) title at the 2014 Games in Incheon.

India thus finished atop the boxing medals tally, signing off with six medals, including three golds, its best-ever performance at the Asian Games in terms of gold medals.

Besides the gold, Priya Ghanghas (60kg), Kapil Pokhariya (90kg) and Narender Berwal (+90kg) won bronze medals.

The country's best overall haul came at the Guangzhou 2010 edition, where the contingent won nine medals -- two gold, three silver and four bronze.

Lovlina defeated China's Ziyi Bao 5-0 on her 29th birthday to upgrade the silver she had won at the last edition. Parveen then eked out a narrow 3-2 split-decision win over Paris Olympic bronze-medallist Chen Nien-chin of Chinese Taipei to claim her maiden Asian Games gold.

Ankush then became the first Indian male boxer since Amit Panghal in 2018 to win an Asian Games gold medal.

"Today is my birthday. It's a very special birthday, I'm feeling really good. I thought I'd have to gift a gold medal on my birthday. It's the first time that I got a present for myself. I gave it my all. I didn't think for a second that I would lose," Lovlina said after the win.

"It was a very tough fight. But I was always thinking that I just have to win. The last round was very tough. I was winning by 2-1 in the first and second round. So I thought I have to just win the third round."

Lovlina made the most of her considerable height advantage, while the 20-year-old Bao constantly tried to close the distance and deny the Indian space to work.

The approach made for a messy contest, with Bao resorting to repeated clinches.

In a departure from her usual approach, Lovlina started aggressively, landing a few punches right away, but Bao was equally fierce with her counters.

The Chinese southpaw connected a couple of combinations, before Lovlina finished the round strongly with some clean, heavy punches to edge it 3-2.

HIGHLIGHTS

- Lovlina and Parveen ended a 12-year wait by joining legendary MC Mary Kom in the select group of Indian women boxers to have won Asian Games gold
- Ankush became the first Indian male boxer since Amit Panghal to win a gold medal

Sujeet seals Asian Games gold

Adds crown to his tally in a stunning year of domination

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Nagoya, October 2



Sujeet Kalkal underlined his growing supremacy in the men's 65kg category by clinching the Asian Games gold here on Friday, defeating an Olympic champion en route to the title and erasing a massive 2-9 deficit in the final to add yet another crown to his tally in a stunning year of domination.

Stronger Iranian and Japanese rivals were expected to make life tough for Sujeet in a tricky draw but it was Tajikistan's Abdulmazhid Kudiev who tested the Indian most by racing to a 9-2 lead.

Using his tremendous speed and technical skills, Sujeet found a way to make a dramatic turnaround and prevail 10-9, scoring eight points in a row and holding off his rival.

Kudiev did not let Sujeet attack by employing arm locks in the first period.

Once Sujeet got a measure of his rival's style he did not let him make any attacking move.

HE THEN PREVAILED 3-3 ON CRITERIA AGAINST JAPANESE OLYMPIC CHAMPION KOTARO KIYOOKA IN THE SEMIFINAL

While Kudiev matched the Indian with strength, Sujeet trumped his rival with speed as he repeatedly went behind the Tajikistan to effect take-down moves.

One after another successful moves reduced the deficit to 8-9 and with about 20 seconds left in the bout, Sujeet found a decisive take down and defended his one-point lead to emerge winner.

Before that thrilling final, Sujeet outclassed Afghanistan's Sayed Omar Zazai by technical superiority (13-3) to begin his campaign and produced a clinical performance against Iran's Abbas Ebrahimzadehsavadkouhi in the quarterfinal, winning by technical superiority without losing a point.

Neeru Dhanda to be flag bearer at closing

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Nagoya, October 2

Ace Indian trap shooter Neeru Dhanda will be the women's flag bearer at the closing ceremony of the Asian Games on Sunday after capping a remarkable campaign with two gold medals and a team silver to emerge as one of the most successful athletes at the continental showpiece.

The 27-year-old will travel back to Nagoya on Saturday morning to lead the Indian contingent at the closing ceremony.

"She is returning to Nagoya tomorrow morning to be the woman flag bearer. The decision on the male flag bearer will be taken tomorrow," deputy chef de mission Anjali Bhagwat said on Friday.

Sailor Nethra Kumanan claims bronze in dinghy

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Gamagori City, October 2

India's Nethra Kumanan on Friday clinched the bronze medal in the women's dinghy event of the Asian Games sailing competition here.

The 29-year-old two-time Olympian from Chennai logged 14 points in all to be placed third behind gold-winner Sophia Montgomery (5) of Thailand and silver-medallist Jania Ang (13) of Singapore.

Indian women's recurve archery team wins gold

Men's and mixed combos claim silver

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Nagoya, October 2

The women's recurve team's stunning win over 10-time Olympic champions South Korea for a historic gold headlined a highly productive day for India in the Asian Games archery competition where the men's recurve and mixed recurve squads signed off with commendable silver medals.

The strong recurve performance comes after the compound archers completed a golden sweep in all the team competitions.

India have so far secured seven medals, including four gold, two silver and a bronze, in the archery event here.

The first medal of the day for the Indian contingent came via the women's recurve trio of Ankita Bhakat, Kirti Sharma and 17-year-old Kumkum Mohod, who held their nerve in challenging windy conditions to outshoot the defending champions 5-3 (54-54, 56-56, 55-51, 54-54) and script a memorable triumph. Kumkum then returned to the range with Dhiraj Bommadevara and combined for a silver medal in the mixed recurve team event, with the Indian duo going down 3-5 (34-38, 35-37, 37-36, 37-37) to China in the final.

The day ended with the men's recurve combination of Bommadevara, Sanjay Bhoge and Neeraj Chauhan settling for a silver following a 1-5 loss (56-56, 50-57, 54-56) to Korea.

The women's triumph capped an upward curve for the Indian recurve team, which had ended a five-year wait for a World Cup gold in Shanghai in May by defeating Korea in the semifinals en route to the title. It was largely the same combination that that competed here, with Kirti replacing former world number one Deepika Kumari, who failed to qualify for the Asian Games through the selection trials.

"We are feeling really good right now, winning gold. This medal is not only for us but our country too, which makes it even sweeter," Kirti said.

"Going into the final we were aware that we would have to perform at our very best, we were not talking about it's China, or Korea, or anything like that, we were just focusing on our aim, what we have to do. And we have done that so we are very happy."

The opening two sets were tightly contested, with both teams finishing level at 54 and 56 points respectively in challenging windy conditions.

Korea, featuring Tokyo Olympics gold-medallist Kang Chaeyoung alongside Oh Yejin and Lee Yunji, then faltered in the third set, shooting three consecutive 8s to finish with 52 points.

INDIAN MEN'S TEAM PLACED SIXTH

Veer Ahlawat shoots 65 to move into 10th place at Asian Games 2026

AGENCIES
Nagoya, October 2



India's Veer Ahlawat fired a five-under 65 to move into 10th position after round three of the men's golf event at the Asian Games 2026. Veer (71-68-65) was the best-placed Indian in the men's individual event at six-under 204, trailing leader Joohyung Kim of Korea by six shots.

In the men's team event, where the top two scores of each round are counted, the Indian team occupied sixth place at 11-under 409. Korea led the team event at 20-under 400 at the Kasugai Country Club East Course.

Veer Ahlawat, the 2024 DP World PGTI Order of Merit champion, made six birdies and a bogey during his third round. The highlight of his round were the four birdies on the back-nine.

Saptak Talwar (66-68-71) came up with a one-over 71 in round three to close the day in 11th place at five-under 205.

VEER AHLAWAT, THE 2024 DP WORLD PGTI ORDER OF MERIT CHAMPION, MADE SIX BIRDIES AND A BOGEY DURING HIS 3RD ROUND

Yuvraj Sandhu (71-69-71) also produced a 71 on Friday to be placed tied 23rd at one-over 211.

EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY

E-Tender Notice

E-Tender Notice No. DDU/EL/G/e-Tender/2026-27/12, Date : 01.10.2026

On line (through E-Tendering) for the following work is invited by DRM/Elect/G/DDU for and on behalf of the President of India from experienced and financially as well as technically sound contractors including those enlisted with the Railway, CPWD, BSNL, MES, PWD and other public sector undertakings.

Sl. No. : 01. **Name of Work with its location:** No. DDU/EL/G/P/2026-27/12 Sub- Electrical Work-Modification and conversion of LT/HT Lines with Provision of Smart Meter for Railway Qtrs over DDU Division. **Approx. cost of the work:** Rs. 32313804.82 **Tender closing Date and Time** : 26.10.2026, 15:00 Hrs. **Website particulars of E-Tendering : www.ireps.gov.in.**

Asstt. Divnl. Elect. Engr.(G)
E.C. Railway, DDU.
PR/1052/DDU/ELECT/T/26-27/28

SHREE SAIBABA SANSTHAN TRUST, SHIRDI
At.Post. Shirdi, Tal- Rahata, Dist. A.Nagar - 423 109
Phone No.(02423) 258680, Fax No.02423-258870
(Website - www.sai.org.in) E-mail – hospital.bmw@sai.org.in

E-Tender Notice

E-Tenders are invited on outsource basis for Shree Saibaba Hospital, Shree Sainath Hospital And Premises for the Supply of outsourced manpower for Mechanized Housekeeping (including Machinery) and Paramedical Staff.

The tender details will be available on https://mahatenders.gov.in for downloading. For details and terms & conditions visit our website www.sai.org.in.

Tender Publish Date	:	**03/10/2026 From 11:00 AM**
Pre-Bid Meeting Date & Time	:	**08/10/2026 From 11:00 AM**
Bid submission Start Date	:	**09/10/2026 From 11:00 AM**
Place of Pre-Bid Meeting	:	**Meeting Hall, Near P.R.O. Office, Shirdi**
Last Date for Online Submission	:	**22/10/2026 Up to 05:00 PM**

Goraksha Gadikar, I.A.S
Chief Executive Officer,

Dgipr/2026-27/3046

GAIL Gas Limited
(A wholly owned subsidiary of GAIL (India) Limited)

NOTICE INVITING TENDER / WALK-IN SELECTION OF CONTRACTORS FOR CGD PROJECT

GAIL Gas Limited invites experienced contractors/agencies for **On-the-Spot Walk-In Selection** for execution of **DPNG LMC/GI Works** and **PE Laying Works** in the following GAs:

GA	Scope	Date & Time
Meerut	DPNG LMC/GI Works	07.10.2026 to 09.10.2026, 10:00 AM to 5:30 PM. **Venue:** Conference Room, 3rd Floor, GAIL Gas Limited, GAIL Jubilee Tower, B-35/36, Sector-1, Noida–201301 (U.P.)
Sonipat	DPNG LMC/GI Works	
Sundergarh-Jharsuguda	DPNG LMC/GI Works	
Raisen-Sehore-Shajapur	DPNG LMC/GI Works	
Dewas	DPNG LMC/GI & PE Laying Works	
Giridih-Dhanbad	PE Laying Works	

Eligibility & Documents Required:
Interested bidders are required to submit relevant supporting documents, including but not limited to, Work Experience Certificates/ Completion Certificate, Registration Certificate, PAN Card, PF Registration Certificate (wherever applicable), ESI Registration Certificate (wherever applicable), Details of available manpower, machinery, and equipment required for execution of the works.

The bidder shall submit a copy of at least one work order awarded during the last seven (07) years as proof of experience in execution of PNG connection/pipeline-related works in the gas, water supply, drainage, telecom, or any other utility sector for GAIL/GAIL Gas and/or their Group Companies, or for any other company.

The Walk-in Selection Process is scheduled to be conducted over the above-mentioned three days. However, if the selection process concludes earlier, no requests for submission of bids from bidders will be entertained thereafter.

Detailed Terms & Conditions Detailed Terms & Conditions are available at: **https://gailgas.com/eoi/expression-interest:**

Contact: Arnab Samanta – 7055515333 | Sandeep Sharma – 9599477955 | Saksham Gupta – 9988092246 | Anil Kumar – 7763807378

Note: Any corrigendum/addendum/clarification/amendment shall be hosted only on the GAIL Gas website. Bidders are advised to visit the website regularly for updates.

Corporate Identification Number: U40200DL2008GOI178614

EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY

E-TENDER NOTICE

The **Divisional Railway Manager (Engg)/ E.C.Railway/Samastipur** for and on behalf of the President of India invites Open Tender from experienced and financially capable tenderers for the following works **in E-Tendering mode of IREPS web portal of Indian Railways :-**

Sl.No. : 1, **Tender Notice No.** : TC-148-2026-SPJ, **Name of work:** Samastipur Division- Provision of Rubberised road surface pad at different Level Crossing - 2020 metre., **Tender Value. (In ₹):** 343729653.95, **Earnest Money (In ₹):** 6874600.00, **Completion period of the work:** 18 Months.

1. Last Date & time for receiving of Tender in E-Tender mode on IREPS web portal:- 03.11.2026 upto 12.00 hours. **2. Opening Date & time for E-Tender:** 03.11.2026 after 12.00 hours. **3. Website particulars where complete details of tender & tender document can be seen on Website: www.ireps.gov.in.** Amendments /modifications, if any shall not be published in the newspapers but the same shall be uploaded in the website.

Sr. Divisional Engineer/Co-ord
E.C.Railway/Samastipur
PR/1053/SPJ/ENGG/T/26-27/36

EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY

OPEN TENDER NOTICE

Open Tender Notice Inviting Online E-Tender, Tender Notice No. EL-50-DNR-Open-14-2026-27, Danapur

The Divisional Railway Manager, E.C. Railway, Danapur for and on behalf of the President of India is inviting online (E-Tendering) Open from the reputed contractors working in State / Central Govt. having valid Electrical contractor's license for the required voltage level (as per scope of work) issued by State / Central Govt. licensing board for the following works : **Tender No. : EL-50-DNR-Open-14-2026-27, Sl.No.** : 1. **Name of work with its location** : Various Electrical (G) works under different Plan Head (PH) - 53 (CAP), 29 (SF), 42 (CAP) & 51 (CAP & DRF) over DNR Division., **Sl.No. :** 2. **Approx cost of the work :** ₹ 4,27,40,759.00 (Rs. Four Crore Twenty Seven Lakh Forty Thousand Seven Hundred Fifty Nine Only)., **Sl.No. :** 3. **Earnest money to be deposited :** ₹ 8,54,800.00 (Rs. Eight Lakh Fifty Four Thousand Eight Hundred only)., **Sl.No. :** 4. **Date & time for online submission and closing of all above tenders :** Date & time for online submission of tender - 23.10.2026 up to 12.00 Hrs., **Sl.No.** : 5. Website particulars, notice board location where complete details of tender can be seen and address of the office from where all the above tender form can be seen : CRIS website **http://www.ireps.gov.in** Office of the Sr. DEE (G)/ E.C. Rly., Danapur, D.R.M. Building, 1st Floor, East Central Railway, Danapur. **NOTE:** All corrigendum will be uploaded on website before 15 days, if required.

Divisional Railway Manager (Elect./G),
E.C.Railway, Danapur
PR/1054/DNR/ELECT/T/26-27/44

Nushrratt Bharuccha suffers spinal fracture in Bali

The actress to undergo surgery in Mumbai

Nushrratt Bharuccha has suffered a fracture in her spine following an accident in the Indonesian capital, Bali and arrangements are being made to bring her back to Mumbai, where she will undergo surgery, her publicist said.

The actress is under medical observation at a hospital in Bali, where she was on a work-and-holiday trip, the publicist said.

"Nushrratt Bharuccha, who was in Bali for a work-cum-holiday trip, met with an unfortunate accident and suffered a fracture in her spine. She is currently hospitalised in Bali and remains under medical observation. Following further evaluation by the doctors, Nushrratt will be undergoing spine surgery. At present, our immediate priority is her health and ensuring she receives the necessary medical care. We are currently making arrangements to bring Nushrratt back to Mumbai from Bali via an air ambulance, where she will undergo the surgery," the publicist said.

THE ACTRESS IS UNDER MEDICAL OBSERVATION AT A HOSPITAL IN BALI, WHERE SHE WAS ON A WORK-AND-HOLIDAY TRIP

Given the nature of the injury and the surgery, Bharuccha will require time to rest and recover and her work commitments over the next few weeks are likely to be affected, the statement added.

The publicist requested that people respect her privacy and allow her space to focus on her treatment and recovery. "We are grateful for everyone's concern and good wishes and will share further updates as and when appropriate," the statement said.

Bharuccha will next feature in an upcoming action film starring Tiger Shroff and directed by Remo D'Souza. PTI





'Wanted to end Drishyam franchise on a high'

Abhishek said there's no plan to extend the Hindi franchise

Director Abhishek Pathak said there is no plan to extend the 'Drishyam' Hindi franchise further with a fourth instalment, as he wants to move on to another story rather than repeat the story and the character for commercial reasons.

Pathak, who directed the second and third parts of the fan-favourite crime-thriller film with Ajay Devgn in the lead, said he decided to conclude the story during the script writing process.

PATHAK DIRECTED THE SECOND & THIRD PARTS OF THE FAN-FAVOURITE CRIME-THRILLER FILM

"I want to end this film here because I think we have written really well. We've reached the point of the film where people will get a good high from it. So, I think making a fourth part, juicing out the same characters and track, isn't correct for the franchise. A trilogy is good," the director told PTI in an interview.

He added, "Somewhere I feel it might just be forcing it for the business perspective; I'd rather make another film and make money than just do another part for this film and creatively restrict myself with this whole world again."

The franchise, inspired by the original in Malayalam cinema, began with the late filmmaker Nishikant Kamat-directed 'Drishyam' in 2015, followed by another part in 2022 and 'Drishyam 3'.

The story centres on Vijay Salgaonkar (Ajay Devgn), a cable operator who goes to extraordinary lengths to protect his family after his daughter becomes involved in a crime. The third chapter, also starring Tabu, Rajat Kapoor and Jaideep Ahlawat, will explore the cat-and-mouse game between Vijay and the police as the case continues to unfold.

Pathak said he is familiar with the fandom around 'Drishyam' and how audiences may want to see more of Vijay Salgaonkar and his family, but they should accept the third film as a 'farewell'. AGENCIES

'Fast & Furious' franchise expands to TV with Peacock series

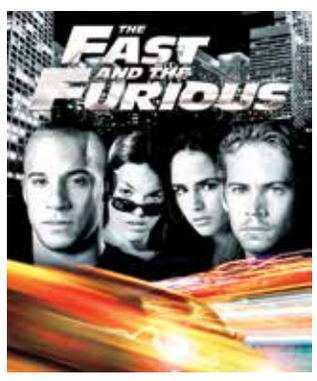
The yet-to-be-titled series will debut in 2028

The 'Fast & Furious' franchise is expanding to television with American streaming service 'Peacock' greenlighting a new scripted series based on the long-running action film series.

The yet-to-be-titled series, which will debut in 2028, will be written by Mike Daniels, known for 'Sons of Anarchy', 'Shades of Blue' and 'The Rockford Files' and Wolfe Coleman. The duo will serve as co-showrunners, pilot writers and executive producers, reported 'Variety'.

Vin Diesel, who has headlined the franchise as protagonist Dominic Toretto since the first film in 2001, will executive produce the series alongside One Race's Sam Vincent, Original Film's Neal H Moritz and Pavun Shetty, Jeff Kirschenbaum and Chris Morgan.

The series was first announced as being in development by Diesel during



NBCUniversal's upfront presentation in May. At the time, the actor said the filmmakers had spent years considering how to expand the stories and legacy characters into television.

The planned 2028 premiere will coincide with the release of 'Fast Forever', the next film in the franchise, which is scheduled to hit theatres on March 17, 2028. Louis Leterrier, who directed 'Fast X', is returning to direct the film.

THE PLANNED 2028 PREMIERE WILL COINCIDE WITH THE RELEASE OF 'FAST FOREVER', THE NEXT FILM IN THE FRANCHISE, WHICH IS SCHEDULED TO HIT THEATRES ON MARCH 17, 2028

The 'Fast & Furious' franchise began with 'The Fast and the Furious' in 2001, starring Diesel as Dominic Toretto, the late Paul Walker as Brian O'Conner, Michelle Rodriguez as Letty and Jordana Brewster as Mia.

The series previously made its way to television through the animated show 'Fast & Furious: Spy Racers', which ran for six seasons on 'Netflix' from 2019 to 2021. PTI

Walton Goggins joins 'Miami Vice '85'

The film is directed by Joseph Kosinski

Walton Goggins is set to feature in Universal's 'Miami Vice '85'.

The 'Boyd Crowder' star will join the previously announced cast comprising Austin Butler as James Crockett, Michael B Jordan as Ricardo 'Rico' Tubbs and Andrew Schulz (his role isn't announced), among others. Goggins will essay the role of a villainous henchman and assassin working for the main cartel kingpin.

The film is directed by Joseph Kosinski and is based on the pilot episode of the landmark 1984-90 NBC series, according to the entertainment news outlet 'Deadline'. It explores the glamour and corruption of mid-1980s Miami. There are no details about the actor's character in the film.

The film is set to be released on May 19, 2028 and is produced by Dylan Clark under Dylan Clark Productions and Kosinski. Actors Whitney Peak, Alden Ehrenreich, Camila Morrone, John Leguizamo and Danny Ramirez round off the cast of the film.

Goggins will also feature in 'Fallout' Season 3, which will release on 'Prime Video' in 2027. He essays the role of Cooper Howard and his mutated, post-apocalyptic alter ego, 'The Ghoul'.



GOGGINS WILL ALSO FEATURE IN 'FALLOUT' SEASON 3

He will also appear in 'Mister', which revolves around his character, who wakes up in a strange house covered in blood and must piece together his true identity while fighting off waves of contract killers. PTI

Katrina's happiness with Vihaan makes Vicky feel 'satisfied'

Kaif and Kaushal welcomed their son in November 2025

Vicky Kaushal and Katrina Kaif welcomed their son Vihaan in November 2025. Since then, he has been quite vocal about his joy of experiencing fatherhood. In a recent chat about becoming a father for the first time and how that has changed his life, Vicky said that it was a 'magical feeling'. He also shared that he has experienced the feeling of being complete and satisfied with his life various times in the last few months.



"You can't quantify change in a sense of how and what has changed, but I can tell you this - it's just such a magical experience; it's a magical feeling that I don't know if there will be enough words to really explain the detail of how you actually feel," Vicky said in a chat shared on the 'YouTube' channel of 'Harit Zaveri Jewellers'.

He then went on to elaborate about the special moments that he shared with his son. "Every day, every little moment when your child giggles, their first cry and their first new expression and their first new gesture... It's just amazing to see that, experience that. They say that humans never feel satisfied, but I feel that in the last 10 months, I have lived so many moments where I have felt that this is it, this is complete. I don't want anything more and I have felt that," he said.

Talking about Katrina, Vicky said, "To just see your wife's happiness in that moment and your child giggling and you in that moment... You just feel that if you could pause this, you could just live this more... It's just amazing. I think it makes you incredibly sensitive as a human being. Also, at the same time, it makes you incredibly responsible as a human being, that now you have to practice what you preach."

Vicky shared that he has now started monitoring his behaviour, as his son's first learnings will come from what he sees at home. "Your child's first learning is going to be subconsciously what he sees at home and he is going to be taking all those things in," he said. AGENCIES



'IT'S JUST SUCH A MAGICAL EXPERIENCE,' SAYS VICKY KAUSHAL